

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

Preface

The Challenges of the AI Era and the Need for Hwajaeng (Reconciliation of Disputes)

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

Preface

As humanity enters the AI era, it faces internal crises such as the threat of mass unemployment, and externally it confronts crises in which war scenarios that, before the AI era, remained mere possibilities are now being pushed to their extreme, as seen in the US-Iran war. Consequently, the re-establishment of human identity, together with mutual flourishing and connection through Hwajaeng (和諍, Reconciliation of Disputes), has become an essential task for human survival.

Just as the Eastern proverb says, "Even if the sky falls, there is a hole through which to escape," the West has Gödel's incompleteness theorems. This is the theorem that no matter how perfect a logic may be—like that of AI—there can never be a logic entirely without gaps (Kim Sang-il 2003). That humanity has an answer is certain; the key now is to find the method.

The re-establishment of human identity can be found in the method of Correlative Thinking, which sees the whole first. Much of the mass unemployment brought about by AI today stems from flawed decisions biased toward analytical methods that see the part before the whole. Humanity's traditional Correlative Thinking methods—which see the whole before the part—for example, the Eastern modes of ipche/transcendence (stereoscopic thinking), sunhwan (cyclical thinking), gonggam (empathy), and yunghap (convergence), can serve as methodological alternatives to the errors of AI's analytical thinking, which fails to survey the connected whole—errors such as confirmation bias and cognitive dissonance. It is the same principle as how, when looking down at a mountain from its summit, one easily discovers what was never visible from the foot of the mountain. Furthermore, humanity's development of artificial intelligence goes beyond mere technological innovation; it amplifies conflicts among nations, groups, and classes, and gives rise to new forms of opposition. If ipche/transcendence, sunhwan, gonggam, and yunghap are theories of individual Correlative Thinking, then Hwajaeng, developed within Buddhism, can be called the application of Correlative Thinking as it relates to the

community.

Hwajaeng has also developed in a differentiated manner within Buddhism according to circumstances. Hwajaeng first began from the binary relationship of arising-and-ceasing (生滅, saengmyeol) and suchness (眞如, jinyeo); later, with the emergence of Yogacara (唯識, Consciousness-only), it became the Three-Natures (三性, samseong)—that is, a ternary relationship; and thereafter, with the rise of the Pure Land school (淨土宗) and others, it developed into a quaternary relationship. The problems humanity confronts today likewise ultimately arise from the collision of four economic theories, which can be resolved through the quaternary relationship of Hwajaeng. In Part I (Theory), this book presents the four modes of Correlative Thinking—ipche (立體, stereoscopic), sunhwan (循環, cyclical), gonggam (共感, empathy), and yunghap (融合, convergence)—and in Part II (Application), it links these to the Four-Gate (四門, Sammun) structure of Wonhyo's theory of Hwajaeng to present a method for a Symbiotic Connective Economy.

“At the foot of Mount Wangbang, April 2026”

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1. Introduction

The Fundamental Questions of the AI Era and the Need for New Modes of Thinking

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

1. Introduction

The greatest question of the AI era is, in fact, a question about the human being rather than about technology itself. The more machines write, draw, and predict, the more human beings must re-explain "why do I matter?" This book foregrounds Correlative Thinking because the human being is not a mere information-processing device but a holistic being who forms relationships, creates meaning, and shares responsibility.

The term Correlative Thinking sounds difficult, but its meaning is simple. It is a perspectival way of thinking that, rather than breaking things apart into separate pieces, looks at how they are connected to one another. For example, Correlative Thinking is not merely observing the fact that it is raining, but considering together how that rain changes a student's walk to school, a farmer's harvest, a city's drainage system, and even a person's mood.

This perspective is especially important in the AI era. AI may be overwhelming in sheer volume of information, but the task of responsibly binding together what that information means for people and communities, all the way through, must be done by human beings.

1.1. The Threshold of the Technological Singularity and the Place of the Human

We live in a Hyperconnected era in which intelligent machines link every domain of life ever more tightly. Artificial intelligence (AI) now goes beyond simple computation or the automation of repetitive tasks, penetrating deeply into fields once regarded as uniquely human—from creative artistic activity to complex decision-making. As AI grows ever more sophisticated, exercising even creativity and intuition, people around the world are posing a question in which awe and anxiety intersect: "What, then, makes the human being special?" In a society led by AI, what can human beings do, and on what foundation can they survive and flourish?

Amid this paradigm shift, human beings face the grave concern that they may be reduced from "choosing beings" who design and control technology to beings who are "chosen or overlooked" by algorithms. The job market, information feeds, and even social interactions are increasingly mediated by AI systems that filter, select, and decide. This goes beyond the mere problem of job loss; it suggests that social control may be transferred, subtly yet profoundly, to AI and its designers. Such a shift may lead to a deep existential crisis concerning human value, purpose, and uniqueness, and any survival strategy must therefore address this existential dimension, not merely technological adaptation.

1.2. The Limits of Analytical Thinking and the Rise of Correlative Thinking

We have seen the reality in which the place of the human is threatened by the technological singularity. How, then, should we break through this existential crisis? The isolated analytical thinking of the West alone cannot surmount this crisis. Now is the inevitable moment when the uniquely human "Correlative Thinking"—which reads the world in a convergent way by connecting all things—must come to the forefront of the world.

Traditional strategies for human development—namely analytical reasoning, specialization, and linear planning—are revealing their limits in effectively responding to the complex, rapidly changing problems of an AI-saturated modern society. The very analytical methods that built the modern world now struggle to cope with the complex and fast-changing problems of an AI-saturated society. We are caught in a kind of existential dilemma: how can we solve, using the very same approach, the problems created by an analytical and mechanistic approach?

There are clear fissures in the current approach. In the economy, fierce competition and reductionist metrics of success alienate individuals and render society unequal. In education, once AI learns to perform a task, education for narrow expertise can be rendered useless overnight—a change that also shakes the very foundations of a credential-centered society. Culturally, the relentless focus on logic and efficiency has brought great progress, but it has often come at the sacrifice of community, creativity, and mental well-being. We are witnessing a world rife with the paradox of being materially abundant yet emotionally unfulfilled, globally connected yet often severed from meaning.

These "fissures" are better understood not as newly arising from AI, but as the result of vulnerabilities inherent in existing systems being further amplified and made visible through AI as a catalyst. AI deepens existing inequalities and the crisis of expertise, serving to reveal systemic flaws all the more clearly. In particular, "severance from meaning" is a serious

problem that appears as a result of excessive reliance on the analytical, efficiency-centered paradigm; and if AI is introduced without holistic value judgment, this crisis of meaning may deepen further. Because AI is itself a product of the analytical tradition, if its deployment and use are guided solely by efficiency, there is a great risk of accelerating human alienation and the loss of purpose.

In the face of this challenge of our times, this report proposes that clues to the answer can be found in "a vibrant ancient intellectual tradition"—in particular, in East Asia's "Correlative Thinking (相關的思惟)" or "holistic relational reasoning." Correlative Thinking is a way of understanding the world through analogy, connection, and context, without dividing everything into fragments. It is rooted in the holistic worldview of yin-yang, the Five Phases (Wuxing), and other concepts of East Asian philosophy and cosmology. Crucially, it is also a way of thinking that encompasses the whole human being—not only the intellect but also the body, emotions, and intuition.

Correlative Thinking is not a mere nostalgic return, but a "practical survival strategy" that enables human beings to exercise their unique strengths in the AI era—finding meaning amid chaos, empathizing deeply with others, connecting disparate domains, and adapting through creativity and ethical insight—roles that AI cannot perform. The ultimate goal is a new "human-AI co-evolution" that reaffirms the meaning of human existence in harmony with intelligent machines.

1.3. The Purpose and Method of This Study

We have confirmed that, beyond the limits of analytical thinking, Correlative Thinking is needed. How, then, can this vast framework of thought be concretely applied to reality? To this end, this study takes as its methodology a four-stage framework running through Daoism, Buddhism, and Confucianism—the roots of the Eastern spirit—and develops its discussion concretely.

The four stages this book presents are not ornamental philosophical jargon. Ipche (stereoscopic thinking) allows one to see many facets together; sunhwan (cyclical thinking) allows one to read the rhythm of change; gonggam (empathy) allows one to fathom the heart of relationships; and yunghap (convergence) allows one to bind together disparate elements to create new value. The four stages can be seen as four lenses for interpreting reality.

In particular, expressions such as X and -X are not symbols to be memorized like mathematical formulas, but signposts marking the direction of thought. X points to one position or property, and -X points to another direction that is opposite or symmetrical to it. What matters is not eliminating one of the two, but seeing what kind of relationship the two form.

Rendered into the everyday life of students: seeing a single problem from multiple perspectives is ipche; reading the repetition of failure and recovery as growth is sunhwan; reading together the hearts of friends and teachers is gonggam; and connecting knowledge from Korean, social studies, and science to create new answers is yunghap.

This study aims to explore the consilience of Eastern and Western thought as a survival strategy for human beings in the AI era, and in particular the possibility of a contemporary application of Correlative Thinking. To this end, it concretizes Correlative Thinking into a four-stage framework—ipche (立體, Mimesis), sunhwan (循環, Mythos), gonggam (共感, Logos), and yunghap (融合, Theos)—and discusses how each stage can respond to the challenges of the AI era. This

framework aims to go beyond the mere presentation of philosophical concepts to provide practical guidelines for personal and social adaptation.

Stage 1 is Mimesis-based ipche (stereoscopic): centering on Daoist thought, it explores the interdependence of opposites and their harmonious generation. (X is -X, and -X is X)

Stage 2 is Mythos-based sunhwan (cyclical): centering on Buddhist thought, it examines nonlinear development and relational generation. (X is neither -X nor X)

Stage 3 is Logos-based gonggam (empathy): centering on Confucian thought, it seeks clear relational ordering and the expansion of communal order. (X is X, and -X is -X)

Stage 4 is Theos-based yunghap (convergence): centering on Western (Abrahamic) religious thought as a fourth mode of thought, it explores the power of convergence that crosses boundaries to create new value. (X is everything, $\forall X$). Here, "Western religion" refers to the entire Abrahamic lineage of religions—that is, Protestantism, Catholicism, and Islam.

This four-stage framework critically examines both Eastern Correlative Thinking and Western Analytical Thinking, and by approaching AI and hyperconnectivity with "a mode of thinking that sees both the forest and the trees, both the connections and the nodes," it will enable an integrated and rich response to the challenges of the AI era. This report seeks to draw insights from both Eastern Correlative Thinking and Western Analytical Thinking. As the expression goes, "the Western and Eastern intellectual traditions are like the two halves of a whole brain"; what matters is "rebalancing" the holistic dimension that has been relatively undervalued in modern society. Such a "Consilience" of Eastern and Western thought enables a more integrated and rich response to the challenges of the AI era.

What cannot be seen no matter how meticulously one looks from the foot of the mountain can be grasped at a single glance from the summit. The human body, which AI lacks, becomes the foundation of Correlative Thinking, and this becomes the means of seeing all the knowledge AI possesses at a single glance from the mountaintop.

"Consilience" goes beyond a mere academic blending; it signifies the essential cognitive evolution required for humanity to manage AI effectively. Although AI is itself primarily a product of Western analytical thinking, its influence carries a complexity that requires the holistic understanding of the East. True consilience means using analytical tools to understand the mechanisms of AI, while employing correlative wisdom to guide its purpose and integration. It is also, together with a critique of intellectual hegemony, an assertion of the equal validity and necessity of diverse worldviews in solving global challenges.

The following table presents a comparison of the principal features of Analytical Thinking and Correlative Thinking.

Table 1: A Comparison of Analytical Thinking and Correlative Thinking

Feature	Analytical Thinking (mainly Western)	Correlative Thinking (mainly Eastern)
Primary mode of reasoning	Reductionist, bottom-up	Holistic, top-down (or whole-first)
Relation of part and whole	Understanding the whole through the parts (sum of parts = whole)	Understanding the parts within the whole (the whole is greater than the sum of its parts)
Treatment of causality	Linear, direct cause-and-effect	Networked, resonant, mutual influence
Treatment of context	Analysis in separation from context	Context-dependent; context defines meaning
Use of logic	Formal logic; deductive/inductive logic	Analogical logic, metaphor, symbol
View of change	Linear, predictable (or exponential)	Cyclical, transformative, spiral
Attitude toward ambiguity	Preference for clarity, avoidance of ambiguity	Acceptance of ambiguity, embrace of paradox
Primary goal	Prediction, control, efficiency	Harmony, appropriateness, balance
Key associated concepts	Scientific methodology, data analysis, objectivity	Yin-yang, the Five Phases (Wuxing), resonance (感應, gam-eung), qi (氣), Dependent Origination (緣起, yeon-gi)

Feature	Analytical Thinking (mainly Western)	Correlative Thinking (mainly Eastern)
Strengths	Precision, clarity, capacity to solve specific problems, driving force of technological advancement	Understanding of complex systems, creation of meaning, adaptability, long-term perspective, ethical insight
Limits in the AI era	Vulnerability to systemic problems, ethical dilemmas, loss of meaning, and human alienation	Difficulty of quantification and immediate prediction; traditional difficulty of scientific verification (currently seeking points of contact with modern science)

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2. The First Method of Correlative Thinking — Ipche (立體, Stereoscopic Thinking)

Daoist Mimesis: X is -X, and -X is X

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2. The First Method of Correlative Thinking — Ipche (立體, Stereoscopic Thinking)

2.1. The Definition of Stereoscopic Thinking

Rendered in the simplest terms, stereoscopic thinking (ipche) is "the power not to draw a conclusion from seeing only one side." If you view a box only through a single photograph, you see only its front; but if you actually hold it in your hand and turn it, you can understand its sides, its back, and even its inner structure. Stereoscopic thinking is the ability to turn the box of thought and examine it.

The same holds for conflicts between people. If you see only the scene in which a friend behaved rudely, it is easy to conclude that the whole of that friend is a "bad person." But when you also consider the situation of that day, the emotions, the misunderstandings, and the history of the relationship, the structure of the event becomes far more complex. Stereoscopic thinking does not erase the wrongdoing, but it makes a more accurate and fair judgment possible.

In the AI era, such stereoscopy is all the more important. AI can quickly capture surface patterns, but the task of deeply fathoming why such a situation arose and whom that judgment might wound, and how, is something human beings must take responsibility for.

The first stage, "ipche (立體, stereoscopic thinking)," refers to the capacity to grasp reality and problems in a multidimensional and in-depth manner, departing from a single-track or flat perspective. It is the process of recognizing the structure and connectivity behind phenomena and building a "solid" understanding by integrating diverse perspectives. Human understanding is rooted deeply in "the body, emotions, and intuition," beyond abstract data processing. AI can process vast amounts of data, but it lacks the "Qualia"—the subjective texture that humans experience—and genuine "intentionality." Such embodied, experiential knowledge provides a depth of understanding that AI cannot replicate. For example, Beijing opera is a paragon of "embodied meaning," conveying rich, analogical meaning through gesture, color, and sound, and engaging the audience "bodily and emotionally" as well. This is a multilayered, non-literal mode of communication. Moreover, drama therapy, which aids psychological healing through

role-play and storytelling, was inspired in part by Eastern theatrical forms such as Beijing opera, demonstrating that embodied, multisensory engagement can bring about deep understanding and transformation.

"Stereoscopic thinking" is a direct response strategy to AI's mode of data processing—that is, to its vast but often flat enumeration of information. If AI can view a broad range of data, then human beings must, through "ipche," grasp the depth of those data points, their interrelated structure, and their non-quantitative aspects such as ethical layers and emotional context. Such in-depth contextual understanding is essential for wise decision-making grounded in the data that AI provides. The emphasis on "embodiment" highlights that human survival is linked to physical, lived experience, providing a distinctive epistemological reference point in an increasingly dematerialized, AI-mediated world. Concepts presented in the research literature, such as "stereoscopic yin-yang and the Five Phases (Park Yong-gyu, 2017)" and "Structure Theory (Kim Dong-ryeol, 2010)," suggest concrete methodological approaches that deepen this stereoscopic understanding. Structure Theory explores the "regularities found at points of connection" among phenomena and "integrates diverse fields of mathematics into a single coherent logical system," thereby seeking to understand the fundamental structures that endow phenomena with "stereoscopy." This is a matter of grasping generative principles beyond superficial phenomena, and is crucial for intervening effectively in the complex systems of the AI era.

2.2. Daoist (道教) Mimesis

We have understood that stereoscopic thinking is the discernment of the interdependence between opposites. This interdependence appears not as an abstract symbol but as the dynamic vitality of reality. We can find it vividly in Daoist Mimesis—the oldest wisdom of the East, which seeks the "essential root."

Mimesis, first used to mean "imitation" in the ancient Greek Aristotle's *Poetics*, denotes not mere mimicry but the creative capacity to sensuously re-present and embody the world. The modern philosopher Paul Ricoeur saw it as the root of the "narrative identity" from which human stories are made, and the Korean scholar of religion Professor Chung Chin-hong (1988) assigned it to "a primordial Daoism in which religious experience and symbols find their roots and become concretely embodied within the human body and life." In this book, Mimesis is applied as Daoist vitality—that is, the initial spiritual dynamism that seeks to transform the abstract world into a concrete body.

Preserving the original meaning of Mimesis as imitation, the stage in which spirit imitates the human being and comes to possess a body can be called Daoist Mimesis. Because the body possesses a spirit that is opposite to itself, Daoist Mimesis is summarized as "X is -X, and -X is X" (Han Tae-dong 2003).

Indeed, Laozi says that if one calls the Dao (X) the Dao (X), it is not the Dao (-X); that the strongest thing (X) is the weakest water (-X); that Heaven and Earth (X) are not benevolent (不仁, bu-in, -X); that a friend (X) is an enemy (-X) and an enemy (-X) is a friend (X)—thus running through the entire *Dao De Jing* with the single thread of "-X is X."

Han Tae-dong (2023) revealed that East Asian Daoism, Buddhism, and Confucianism, contrary to common assumption, are established upon a rigorous mathematical structure. To explain this simply: regarding, for instance, friend and enemy, Daoism and Confucianism debate as follows. Against Daoism, which calls an enemy (-X) a friend (X), Confucianism holds that an enemy is an enemy and a friend is a friend; in Confucianism, a ruler must be ruler-like and a subject must be

subject-like ($X \rightarrow X$, $\sim X \rightarrow \sim X$). At this point, Buddhism, which appeared later in East Asia, achieved great success by expressing that there is neither friend nor enemy ($X \rightarrow (\sim X \wedge X)$).

At first glance this sentence may feel like wordplay, but its meaning is rather simple. It says that a thing is not entirely severed from its opposite, but rather acquires its own meaning within its relationship to that opposite. Because there is day, we know night; and because there is night, day too becomes vivid.

Rendered into the everyday life of a middle-school student, study and rest are a good example. With only study and no rest, concentration collapses; with only rest and no study, growth halts. If study is X , then rest may be $\sim X$, but the two are not enemies that ruin each other, but a pair that completes each other.

Therefore, " X is $\sim X$, and $\sim X$ is X " does not mean "exactly the same thing." It means that even though they appear opposite on the surface, they are in fact an inseparable relationship, and that within each side there always lies the possibility of crossing over into the other. The wisdom of Daoism lies precisely in reading this complementarity.

The relationship between AI and the human can be seen in this way as well. If AI is strong in analysis and computation, the human can bring into sharper relief the judgment of meaning, responsibility, care, and contextual understanding. The two are not beings that merely compete, but can become mirrors that reflect each other.

Daoist Mimesis, beyond mere imitation, means embodying the order of nature and the principle of change and reflecting these in life. Its core is the principle of complementarity, which can be summarized in the proposition " X is $\sim X$, and $\sim X$ is X ." This is the discernment that opposites, like yin and yang, in fact define each other, depend on each other, and ceaselessly transform into each other. Just as darkness has meaning because there is brightness, and brightness is revealed because there is darkness, so too the relationship between AI and the human can be understood from this complementary perspective.

2.2.1. Artificial Intelligence and the Human: A Complementary Relationship

In the AI era, to view the human and AI as a mere relationship of opposition does not accord with Daoist wisdom. Even though AI appears to imitate human intellectual capacities and to surpass them in certain domains, this does not annihilate human value; rather, it can become an occasion for bringing the uniquely human domain into sharper relief. If AI is "X," the human can be "-X," and vice versa. For example, if AI shows its strengths in the analytical and computational domain (X), the human can all the more exercise its value in the emotional and creative domain (-X). Conversely, human intuition and insight (-X) can form a mutually complementary relationship by giving direction and meaning to AI's data-processing capacity (X). In other words, the advancement of AI is not the end of human capacity, but the opening of new possibilities for how the human can interact with AI and maximize each other's strengths.

Bergson long ago compared the relationship between AI and the human being to that between a machine (X) and an organism (-X). Even a century before AI appeared, in confronting the crisis of the humanities, phenomenology, the philosophy of life, and Bergson himself redefined the relationship between AI and the human being and discovered that the human body, being organic, constitutes what is uniquely human (Kim Hyeong-hyo 1991).

2.2.2. The Leadership of Wu-wei (Non-action):

Wu-wei (Non-action) does not mean 'doing nothing.' Just as a river flows of its own accord until it reaches the sea, wu-wei is action that does not run counter to the direction of nature. Even without forcing, water always flows toward lower ground, and when that flow gathers it becomes an immense force. Leadership in handling AI is the same. Trying to lead AI solely through control and command in fact blocks AI's possibilities. Wu-wei AI leadership means that the human being sets the direction and values, while giving AI the space to seek its best within them.

Time is a representative symbol of wu-wei. The reason the Book of Changes (I Ching) takes wonhyeong-ijeong (origination, growth, harvest, and completion) as its core is that this wonhyeong-ijeong is the power of time, represented by spring, summer, autumn, and winter. Time is like the sun in Aesop's fable, which, in the contest to strip the traveler of his coat, removes it naturally, unlike the wind. The human body's capacity to perform mimesis (imitation) of time is a characteristic unique to the human being.

Some prominent AI developers liken the human being to a capable teacher who, rather than distrusting problem students, places trust in them and changes teaching methods so that these students come to display outstanding ability. Such prominent AI developers regard AI as something to be believed in as one would believe in a god, yet as something that, though possessing god-like ability, cannot exercise that ability in reality without the human being.

To take AI as a mirror means to practice reading the human being's own self in the results that AI shows us. When an AI system renders a judgment biased toward a particular group, that bias is not a problem of AI itself but a reflection of the biases of the human society that trained the AI. Therefore, examining how AI operates is at the same time the work of examining what prejudices and injustices our own society has embedded within it. Just as one sees one's own appearance through a mirror, we need a leadership of reflection that sees the bare face of human civilization through AI and sets about correcting it.

The leadership of wu-wei can also be practiced at the individual level. When a student uses AI, wu-wei use is precisely the process of not immediately taking and writing down the answer, but rather examining and questioning the answer AI presents and comparing it with one's own thinking. In this process the student cultivates a judgment of one's own that goes beyond AI. Not being driven by AI nor blindly following AI, but naturally working together with AI while not losing one's humanity—that is the modern-day wu-wei.

Laozi's thought of 'wu-wei (non-action)' offers an important insight for leadership in the AI era. Wu-wei is not doing nothing, but a leadership that, following the natural order (the Dao), refrains from forced intervention and guides things to be so of themselves (ziran). The human role in handling AI may be similar. While respecting AI's autonomy and learning ability, the human being must exercise an 'indirect leadership' that creates the environment for AI to derive optimal results and presents an ethical direction.

AI is like a mirror (Mimesis) reflecting the complex aspects of human society. The data on which AI learns may contain the very prejudices and contradictions of human society, and the way AI operates simultaneously reveals both the limits

and the possibilities of the human decision-making process. Therefore, through AI we can reflect more deeply on the essence of the human being, the structure of society, and the values we ought to pursue. The wu-wei leader must play the role of reflecting the human being through the mirror of AI and wisely orchestrating things so that technological advancement does not lead to the loss of humanity.

2.3. The First Stage of Generation, Potae (Gestation)

We have examined the leadership of wu-wei, which reflects humanity by taking artificial intelligence as a mirror. If one has awakened to Daoist interdependence and vitality, how does it first reveal its form in reality? The very starting point of that great movement of life is the mysterious stage of 'potae (gestation),' in which the cosmic energy is conceived within the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages.

The Twelve Life-Cycle Stages (sibi-unseong) constitute a typical theory of growth that divides the whole process of life—being conceived, growing, maturing, and becoming active—into twelve stages. Because it is explained through twelve terms—potae (gestation), yangsaeng (nurturing), yokdae (bathing-and-girding), gwanwang (prime), decline, illness, death, and burial—it becomes the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages. If the Ten Heavenly Stems and Twelve Earthly Branches are atoms, then the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages are like the molecules that arise when the Ten Stems and Twelve Branches meet. Because the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages arise where mind and body meet, they are highly suitable as a concept for revealing the human characteristics that AI does not possess. For example, if AI, which manifests only mind, or the cyborg, which reveals only body, are atoms like the Ten Stems and Twelve Branches, then the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages that appear when the Ten Stems and Twelve Branches combine are like molecules. What we encounter in the actual world is the world of molecules.

Potae (gestation) refers to the first stage in which new life, before it has yet come out into the world, grows while being safely protected. One of the most important roles the human being must perform in the AI era is precisely this role of potae. It is the human being's part to create a 'safe space' in which new ideas, new enterprises, and new social connections can sprout. AI produces results quickly, but the judgment to trust, protect, and nurture as-yet-unverified possibilities must be made by the human being.

Translated into the daily life of a middle-school student, potae is creating an environment in which, when starting a new hobby, one can keep trying even if the initial results are poor. When parents encourage the process rather than looking only at scores, and when a teacher draws learning even out of wrong answers, that relationship itself becomes the space of potae. Education in the AI era is the same. The role of the human teacher, who encourages the process of the student making mistakes and learning together with AI, cannot be replaced by AI.

In Eastern thought, 'potae (gestation)' means the first stage in which life is conceived, is protected, and holds within itself new possibilities. In the AI era, the human role lies not in competing with AI as an already-completed being, but in performing the role of 'potae'—conceiving and nurturing the possibilities of a new age. AI technology itself is value-neutral, but its results can vary greatly depending on the intentions and values with which the human being makes use of it. Through the new tool of AI, the human being has the potential to conceive creative ideas unimaginable in the past, to seek innovative methods for solving social problems, and to open a new horizon for human civilization.

2.4. Johwa (Creative Transformation) and Johwa (Harmonizing Attunement) in the AI Era

If, through potae, the possibility of life has been quietly conceived as johwa (creative transformation), then in order for that potential to grow fully and come out into the world, a great balance—johwa (harmonizing attunement)—is essential. There is an urgent need for a breathing in which cold technology (yin) and warm humanity (yang) do not collide but fuse with vitality: the harmonizing attunement (johwa) of the Harmonious Union of Yin and Yang (eumyang-hapdeok) that nourishes all things in creation.

The Harmonious Union of Yin and Yang (eumyang-hapdeok) is a principle of harmonizing attunement (johwa) in which two opposing forces, without suppressing each other, act together to create all things. It is not that yin eliminates yang or that yang dominates yin; rather, the two ceaselessly complement and interact with each other, bringing forth life. The relationship between AI and the human being can also be understood through this principle. When AI's calculative and logical ability (a yang attribute) and the human being's emotional and intuitive ability (a yin attribute) are seen not as opposing but as a pair that completes each other, only then does a civilization in which technology and humanity achieve harmony become possible.

Consider the example of using an AI writing tool at school. Good writing emerges when AI's quick drafting of an outline (the speed and efficiency of yang) works together with the student's refining of that draft through one's own experience and emotion (the depth and authenticity of yin). Using only AI yields content but no individuality; writing without AI may be rich in expression but can suffer from a lack of information. The most polished result comes when the two are joined like yin and yang. This is the modern Harmonious Union of Yin and Yang.

The Harmonious Union of Yin and Yang (eumyang-hapdeok) refers to the principle by which the differing energies of yin and yang are harmoniously joined to generate and develop all things. The ideal picture of the AI era is not one in which technology (yang) and humanity (yin) stand opposed or in which one dominates the other, but one in which each recognizes the other's strengths and, achieving harmony, creates new value. When AI's powerful analytical capacity and efficiency are combined with the human being's warm empathic capacity and ethical judgment, technology can become a tool that enriches human life still further rather than alienating the human being. This harmony of the Harmonious Union of Yin and Yang will become the core principle for setting the direction of technological development in a human-centered way and for building a future in which AI and the human being coexist and flourish together.

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3. The Second Method of Correlative Thinking – Sunhwan (Cyclical Thinking)

Buddhist Mythos: X is neither -X nor X

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

3. The Second Method of Correlative Thinking – Sunhwan (Cyclical Thinking)

In the previous chapter we examined the process by which, through mimesis (Ipche, the stereoscopic), artificial intelligence and the human being take each other as mirrors and seek the 'concrete root of life.' Yet scattered, individual roots and fragmentary entities alone do not make a great civilization. If a single seed has put down roots in the soil (Daoist mimesis), then next there must necessarily be a vast web of relations in which it receives the rain, interacts with others, and is connected into one (Buddhist mythos). This is precisely the inevitable reason we must advance beyond individual existence to the thinking of Chapter Three, Sunhwan (Cyclical thinking)—the 'law of relation and life.'

3.1. Definition of Cyclical Thinking

Cyclical thinking begins from acknowledging the fact that the world does not move only in a straight line. We often think of growth, grades, and the economy all as 'things that must keep rising,' but actual life has a cyclical structure in which ascent and descent, starting and stopping, failure and recovery are repeated.

It is easy to understand by recalling the seasons. Just because the start of spring is good, spring alone cannot continue forever. There must be the expansion of summer, the gathering-in of autumn, and the storing of winter for the next spring to come. Cyclical thinking is a perspective that understands even stopping and decline as part of the whole of life.

It is the same in the AI era. Just because technology advances rapidly does not mean society automatically becomes better. Behind the fervor of growth, adjustment and recovery are needed, and the greater efficiency grows, the more a recovery of ethics and care must follow.

The second stage, 'Sunhwan (Cyclical thinking),' involves understanding life and systems not as static, linear processes but as dynamic, periodic, and regenerative ones. It is the ability to perceive recurring patterns and rhythms and the flow of energy and information. The theory of yin-yang and the Five Phases is a core model of a 'cyclical cosmology.' The Five Phases cycle ceaselessly through relations of mutual generation and mutual overcoming, and yin-yang shows how opposing forces, each containing the seed of the other, are periodically transformed. This cyclical perspective is also connected to an attitude that embraces 'contingency and nonlinear growth.' Accepting unplanned events and recognizing that development is often not linear provides a flexibility that linear, analytical planning is apt to overlook. Indeed, the claim that 'contingency must be included in reasoning' underscores the importance of this openness.

The 'Law of Circulation' (Oh Gwang-gil 2015) is an attempt to show that the Eastern principle of circulation can be scientifically established so as to explain natural phenomena, and even modern physical and chemical phenomena. It

explains that 'all changes in nature perform a cyclical motion through the coexistence, opposition, union, and semi-union of four basic elements (A, B, C, D).' East Asian calendars and philosophies of history often speak of 'beginning, renewal, and periodic flow,' cultivating an adaptive way of thinking.

'Cyclical thinking' provides a framework for long-term sustainability and resilience in the upheaval brought by AI. It emphasizes balance, adaptation, and the understanding that present trends are not permanent. Just as yin-yang logic anticipates 'reversal and dialectical change' and aims at 'harmonious balance,' a cyclical perspective prevents panic or fatalism amid the rapid and often unstable changes of the AI era. It suggests that even if AI creates extreme 'yang' situations (e.g., hyper-efficiency, job displacement), a 'yin' counteraction (e.g., a focus on human relationships, new forms of labor) can arise naturally or be deliberately cultivated. This promotes active adaptation rather than passive fear.

Embracing 'contingency' within a cyclical worldview is crucial for innovation. AI excels at optimizing on the basis of existing data, but genuine breakthroughs often arise from unexpected, nonlinear discoveries that predictive models miss. A less rigid, cyclical worldview is more open to such 'happy accidents.' This means that creating an environment that allows for exploration, play, and unexpected connections is essential for human creativity to flourish alongside AI. The 'Law of Circulation' is an attempt to elevate cyclical thinking from a merely philosophical or metaphorical concept to a scientifically demonstrable principle. If it succeeds, it will build a powerful 'consilient' bridge between Eastern wisdom and Western scientific verification, making the cyclical strategy more robust and broadly applicable.

3.2. Buddhist Mythos

We have confirmed the theory of the cycle—the nonlinear and rhythmic rhythm of evolution. That all things in the world cycle means that I do not exist alone and independently, but am entangled with countless others, ceaselessly forming relations. This is precisely the essence of Buddhist mythos, in which the individual root expands endlessly into a vast 'narrative of relation.'

Mythos means 'myth' or 'story' in ancient Greek, and Aristotle used it in explaining the plot (structure) of a story as the stage following mimesis. Ricoeur (2012) reinterpreted it such that, if mimesis is the scattered fragments of individual existence, mythos is the power that gathers them and weaves them into 'one connected plot.' In this book, mythos represents the Buddhist worldview of dependent origination, in which individual lives (Daoist roots) are connected as one with others and expand into an infinite 'worldwide relation.'

The Buddhist mythos that succeeds mimesis is summarized in the sentence 'X is neither -X nor X.' Where Daoism says the enemy is a friend, Buddhism—saying 'X is neither X nor -X'—holds that, 'without either friend (X) or enemy (-X),' all things are empty (Sunyata). Buddhism reaches a state in which not even an enemy to be hated can exist, and thereby it cycles all things and nurtures life.

This sentence is more unfamiliar, but its core lies in 'do not fix a being too quickly under a single name.' A person does not exist always in the same form. Yesterday's self differs from today's self, and my self at school differs from my self at home. So one cannot bind me with only a single rigid word.

For example, if we call someone only a 'student who studies well,' that student's anxieties, considerateness, mistakes, dreams, and waverings become hard to see. Conversely, seeing someone only through the name 'student who studies poorly' likewise conceals their true self. Buddhist mythos sees a being not as a fixed label but as a process that

continually arises and changes within relations.

So 'X is neither -X nor X' is not nihilism. Rather, it is a request not to judge things too quickly, but to see the possibility of change and the relationality within them. Growth lies in relation.

Buddhist mythos is a way of exploring the essence of the world and the meaning of human existence through narrative, symbol, and metaphor. Beyond merely mythical stories, it is an attempt to grasp intuitively the deep truth lying behind phenomena. Buddhism's core ideas—Dependent Origination (yeongi), Impermanence (musang), and Emptiness (gong)—form the foundation of this mythos-based understanding. The proposition 'X is neither -X nor X' implies the thought of Emptiness (Sunyata), namely that all beings are without fixed substance, are mutually dependent, and change ceaselessly. That is, no being can be defined as an absolute 'X' or an absolute '-X,' nor is it an 'X' that exists independently in itself.

3.2.1. The Law of Dependent Origination (Pratityasamutpada): Co-evolution

Dependent Origination means 'nothing arises alone.' Not even a single flower can bloom without sunlight and water, soil, wind, and time. Human thought too is influenced by family, friends, school, and society. In this way, existence always arises within relations.

AI likewise does not grow apart from the human being. It grows by learning the data and institutions created by humans, the profit structures of corporations, and the value systems of society, and in turn AI transforms human daily life and ways of judging. This cycle in which the human being makes AI and AI in turn changes the human being can be called co-evolution.

The reason this perspective matters is responsibility. When AI causes a problem, saying only 'the machine did it' makes human responsibility disappear. But from the perspective of dependent origination, humans, institutions, corporations, and culture are all connected to the outcome. Therefore an AI problem is not a problem of technology alone but a problem of shared responsibility.

Dependent Origination (yeongi) is a core Buddhist doctrine that all beings and phenomena arise and cease within mutually dependent relations. The relationship between AI and the human being also cannot be free from this law of dependent origination. AI is born and develops through human needs and knowledge, and at the same time the development of AI exerts a profound influence on the human way of life, way of thinking, and social structure. This can be understood as a process of co-evolution, in which AI and the human being mutually influence each other and evolve together. Beyond the dichotomous view that regards AI as a mere tool or an enemy, it is important to recognize that AI and the human being are in an interconnected relationship in which each becomes the condition of the other's existence.

3.2.2. Impermanence (Anicca) and Emptiness (Sunyata)

Impermanence (musang) is not a frightening or nihilistic concept. Rather, it is a wisdom that makes us realize the preciousness of this present moment. When one acknowledges that yesterday's self and today's self are not entirely the same, the human being becomes a being open to change. Before the rapid changes of the AI era, the person who thinks 'I am a being fixed by this occupation, this ability' grows anxious, but the person who recognizes 'I am a being that changes and is newly generated' adapts flexibly.

If we understand Emptiness (gong) as 'being empty,' it sounds nihilistic, but if we understand it as 'an open state full of possibility,' it sounds entirely different. Only an empty vessel can hold something new. In a mind full of fixed prejudice and inertia, there is no room for the new wisdom of the AI era to enter. The thinking of Emptiness converts the fear 'I am afraid AI will replace me' into the creative openness of asking 'then what new possibilities can I open?'

The concept of relational becoming means, simply put, that 'a person is not a being completed alone but is continually made within relations.' Just as a student grows through teachers and friends, books and experience, the human being of the AI era is also generated into a new form through relations with AI and relations with community. With this perspective, there is no need to see AI as a competitor. For AI is one relation and tool that one encounters in the process of being generated into a better self.

Impermanence (musang) is the truth that all things change ceaselessly and that nothing lasts forever, and Emptiness (gong) is the thought that all beings are empty, without fixed substance. From this perspective, the human being can be understood not as a fixed, unchanging 'Being,' but as a being in a process of 'relational Becoming'—ceaselessly changing and newly formed within relations. To think that the human being's role or value is fixed amid the rapid changes of the AI era runs counter to the principle of impermanence and emptiness. Rather, the human being is a fluid and dynamic being who ceaselessly creates anew one's own meaning and role within relations with AI and with social change. This perspective of 'relational becoming' emphasizes the importance of flexible adaptation to change and continual self-renewal.

3.3. The Concretization of Life, Hyeongche (Form-taking):

The Space of Cessation, Where Form Exists but Substance Does Not

Through the law of dependent origination, we have seen that all beings are firmly entangled in the cosmic web (mythos). If so, how does this vast relational wave concretely take on the form of existence in the world? Here the astonishing mystery in which the yangsaeng (nurturing) of the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages, bordering on Buddhism's ultimate tranquility of cessation (jeongmyeol, nirvana), becomes 'hyeongche (form)' reveals its shape.

To understand the essence of the human being within the process by which life cycles, we need to borrow the concept of the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages (sibi-unseong) from the study of Myeongni (destiny studies). Among these, yangsaeng can be called 'hyeongche (form).' The state of yangsaeng that is formed after potae (gestation) in the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages—namely hyeongche—refers to the state of a child in the mother's womb, 'having taken form but not yet born into the world as a physical substance.' The 'cessation (jeongmyeol, the state of nirvana that is completely still and tranquil)' that Buddhism ultimately pursues means precisely returning to this state of conceived possibility, like the womb of the cosmic mother. This quiet space of the womb, connected by infinite potential, is the point at which the fundamental gazes of Daoism and Buddhism upon human life intersect. However, the hyeongche that has become an adult and entered the stage of liberation contains all the experience of life that the hyeongche of childhood does not have.

The rediscovery of bodily existence becomes paradoxically important in the AI era. The more remote classes and video conferences increase, the greater becomes the value of the experience of actually being in the same space and feeling each other's warmth and breath. Playing an instrument with one's hands, growing vegetables in a garden, making things through craftwork—such bodily activities are not mere hobbies but important practices for maintaining the sense of reality that is being lost in the digital world.

In the AI era, the importance not only of the human being's mental and intellectual capacities but also of 'Embodiment' is being newly highlighted. The human being is not a mere information-processing device, but a being who experiences and interacts with the world with a concrete form (hyeongche).

3.3.1. Qualia and Intuition

Buddhist hyeongche is expressed concretely in the body through the term Qualia. Qualia is a word used in philosophy, but its meaning is simple. The 'feeling of red' one senses upon seeing an apple, the 'ache in the chest' when hearing sad music, the 'sense of being overwhelmed' at the moment of seeing the sea for the first time—this subjective, living texture of experience is qualia. AI can calculate the wavelength of red, analyze the rhythm of sad music, and measure the area of the sea, but it has no experience of actually 'feeling' that red. This difference is the human being's deepest uniqueness.

Intuition is the ability to skip the steps of logical reasoning and see the essence directly. An experienced doctor feeling 'something is wrong' the moment he sees a patient, a skilled teacher knowing from a student's gaze alone whether the student has understood or not—such intuition is the result of accumulated long experience and sensibility. AI recognizes patterns through millions of data points, but this differs from intuition arising from experience lived through the body. In the AI era, human intuition is not diminished but comes to the fore as an even more precious ability that complements what AI misses.

Qualia refers to the subjective and qualitative aspect of experience, such as the feeling of redness or the vividness of pain. AI can analyze vast amounts of data and recognize complex patterns, but it cannot experience such subjective qualia. Moreover, human intuition is an insight that goes beyond logical reasoning, grounded in bodily experience and unconscious information processing. Such qualia and intuition are domains uniquely human, difficult for AI to imitate, and they become important sources of human originality and judgment in the AI era.

The following table compares and presents the essential differences between AI and the human being.

Table 2. Comparison of the Essential Differences Between AI and the Human Being

Category	Artificial Intelligence (AI)	Human
Cognition / Thought	- Capable of abstract information processing and logical reasoning - Data-based learning and knowledge accumulation - Pattern recognition, problem solving, decision-making support - Processing method varies with input information	- Meaning-conferral through Qualia experience and Intentionality - Self-reflection and self-consciousness - Intuitive creativity and imagination
Emotion / Empathy	- Capable of emotion recognition and simulation - Genuine emotional experience is absent	- Genuine emotional experience - Capacity for empathy and solidarity - Formation of existence through relationship and love
Ontological Status	- Functional being, instrumental being - Programmed responses, simulated results - Strength in the domain of 'attributes'	- As 'Dasein,' a being that questions being - Integrated experience of body and mind - A 'substantial' being - Incompleteness and the possibility of growth
Ethics / Responsibility	- Difficulty in ethical judgment - Unclear locus of responsibility - Reflects the bias of training data	- Moral conscience and free will - Responsible decision-making - Respect for human dignity

3.3.2. Embodied Cognition

Qualia is in turn concretized as embodied cognition. Embodied Cognition is a theory that scientifically demonstrates the fact that 'we do not think with the head alone.' When learning the piano, memorizing the score and repeating the keys with one's fingers thousands of times are entirely different kinds of learning. Just as one cannot learn how to ride a bicycle by reading about it in writing, much wisdom can be gained only when the body directly experiences it. For AI, knowledge is data, but for the human being, wisdom is what has been accumulated together with bodily experience.

To make use of embodied cognition in the educational field is to give students ample experience of directly making, cooking, performing plays, debating, and experimenting. The more AI takes over the work of searching for and organizing information, the more the school ought, on the contrary, to become a space of learning experienced through the body. Education in which one only sits at a desk staring at a digital screen is not the education of the AI era; rather,

education that uses the body and awakens the senses is the education more needed in the AI era.

Embodied Cognition is a theory that the human cognitive process is formed through interaction with the body and the environment. We do not think merely with the brain; we experience and learn about the world with the whole body, and this bodily experience is deeply involved in our ways of thinking and our problem-solving abilities. AI learns through data without bodily experience, but the human being accumulates 'embodied wisdom' through concrete experience in the actual world. Such wisdom is essential for coping with complex and unpredictable situations and for understanding subtle contexts. The following table compares and presents the Confucian and Buddhist views of the body.

Table 3. Comparison of the Buddhist and Confucian Views of the Body

Category	Buddhism (including the Mahayana Yogacara perspective)	Confucianism (including the perspective of self-cultivation and family regulation)
Essence of the Body	- 'I am not the body' as the core of practice (dis-identification) - At the same time, a positive aspect as the 'sole instrument' for eliminating karma and escaping the cycle of rebirth - Body-mind continuum - Sustaining life through the appropriation (執受) of the alaya-vijnana	- A precious thing received from one's parents (身體髮膚 受之父母, the body, hair, and skin are received from one's parents) - Unity of body and mind (心正而后, 身修: when the mind is rectified, the body is cultivated) - The practical foundation of intellectual experience (experience, embodiment)
Role of the Body	- Essential medium for spiritual progress and liberation - An intellectual dimension made up of 'consciousness (識),' distinguishing humans from animals	- The foundation of 'self-cultivation (修身)' - The basis for governing family, state, and all-under-heaven - Practical proof of the unity of knowledge and action (知行一致) - The extension of self-respect and respect for others
Implications for the AI Era	- In contrast to AI's non-bodily existence, emphasizes the importance of human 'experience' and 'consciousness' - Provides a philosophical basis for discussions of bodily manipulation in the posthuman era	- Emphasizes the value of 'embodied wisdom' and 'practical ethics' in contrast to AI's intellectual ability - Rediscovered the contemporary meaning of self-cultivation and family regulation as strengthening 'humanity'

3.4. The Second Stage of Growth, Yangsaeng (Nurturing Life): The Moment of Great Birth That Western Thought's Four Hundred Years Passed By

We have experienced the faint stillness of 'hyeongche,' which has form but has not yet been born out into the world. Now that sacred and latent spirit must break its shell and surge forth, born as physical vibration out into the world. The leap of 'yangsaeng (nurturing life)'—in which the most powerful concrete body is first bestowed, a miracle that artificial intelligence (AI) can never imitate—finally unfolds before our eyes.

In general, when we hear the word "yangsaeng" (養生), we tend to think of the dietary regimen and health management spoken of in Daoism. In this paper, however, yangsaeng refers to the ontological leap in the cosmic generative process of the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages, whereby the "spirit" that arose through potae (胞胎) first grows and comes to possess a "concrete, physical form (the body)" within the mother's womb. This wondrous moment of genesis, in which mimesis (spirit) is first transformed into body, is precisely what decisively distinguishes humans from AI. Artificial intelligence may compute vast quantities of data, but it can never undergo the process of yangsaeng, through which it would acquire a physical corporeality (Body) of its own.

Following this current of thought leads us to a profound insight. The Buddhist scholar Jeong Sang-gyo (2025) states, "Daoism seeks roots, while Buddhism seeks relationships." Because there exists the process of yangsaeng, in which mimesis first acquires a body (the Daoist root), it becomes possible for those individuated beings to connect and extend to one another through mythos (the Buddhist realm of relationship and narrative). Therefore, in the spiritual history of humankind, Daoism comes first, and upon its foundation Buddhism must necessarily follow; that Confucianism, which defines good and evil, then emerges, becomes an inevitable rhythm of the cosmos. In the past, the East, for some four

hundred years, failed to recognize the brilliant development of the West's material civilization and thus endured an age of historical suffering and colonization. Yet conversely, the West too, over the past four hundred years, raced ahead without comprehending at all this great spiritual civilization of the East (the cycle of Daoism–Buddhism–Confucianism and the generative wisdom of the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages). The arrogance of Western material civilization, which pursued to the extreme only efficiency and calculative intelligence (a part of Logos) while lacking roots and relationships, has ultimately led to the present existential crisis in which cold artificial intelligence (AI)—one that has not passed through the soul-endowed process of "yangsaeng"—threatens humanity itself, and this leads to the Iran–United States war of 2026. This is the core reason why, in the AI era, we must once again draw upon the life-principle of the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages.

Although yangsaeng refers to the yangsaeng of the fetal stage, it can also be understood as the yangsaeng of a process of completion—recovery from a state that is already mature yet not yet whole. Here too, yangsaeng reveals a bodily characteristic unique to humans that AI cannot know. Let us consider a concrete method of yangsaeng in the AI era through the daily life of a middle school student: spending thirty minutes after class walking or drawing without a smartphone; turning off notifications in the evening and having face-to-face conversations with family; and on weekends running and playing in nature without digital devices—all of these are practices of modern yangsaeng. Only when the body is healthy is the mind healthy, and only when the mind is healthy does one gain the power to solve the complex problems of the AI era creatively.

Yangsaeng also encompasses the health of social connection. It is not a yangsaeng done alone but a yangsaeng done together. When the web of relationships in which we care for one another—within family, friends, neighbors, and community—remains alive, an individual's resilience is likewise heightened. In the AI era, the more the platform economy increases the number of people working alone, the more precious, paradoxically, become relationships of face-to-face care shared among real people. The Symbiotic Connective Economy of Hwajaeng is, in the end, also the socioeconomic expression of this "yangsaeng done together."

Yangsaeng (養生) refers, in the Eastern tradition, to the method of nurturing and preserving life in health, and it places importance on mental and physical harmony and balance. The rapid changes and information overload of the AI era can become new sources of stress for human beings. Accordingly, in the AI era, the wisdom of yangsaeng—caring for mental and physical health—becomes all the more important. This includes dissolving the fatigue and anxiety caused by excessive use of digital technology, and cultivating inner tranquility and resilience, through regular living, appropriate exercise and rest, mindfulness and meditation, and communion with nature.

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

4. The Third Method of Correlative Thinking – Gonggam (Empathy, 共感)

Confucian Logos: X is X, and -X is -X

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4. The Third Method of Correlative Thinking – Gonggam (Empathy, 共感)

4.1. The Meaning of Empathic Thinking: The Universal Driving Force the West Borrowed and Changed the World With

In Chapter 3, through the Buddhist mythos (cyclicity), we confirmed that all things in heaven and earth are intimately bound in "relationship" as one vast organic web. However, the mere realization that everything is connected cannot substantively control real-world conflicts and threats (particularly the ethical challenges of artificial intelligence). Within the connected web of relationships, we must discern what is right and wrong—good and evil (善惡)—and establish a clear order (Logos). For this reason, thought necessarily passes through Daoism and Buddhism and moves on to the thinking of Gonggam (Empathy, 共感) in Chapter 3, which is completed upon the Confucian foundation of ethical standards and social responsibility.

We generally regard "empathy" as no more than a private disposition of emotionally sympathizing with another's sorrow. From a world-historical perspective, however, empathy (Sympathy/Empathy) was the immense driving force of a revolution that shook the world (Hwang Tae-yeon 2023). The Enlightenment thinkers of Europe (Leibniz, Voltaire, and others) translated and actively interpreted the Confucianism of the East, in particular the concepts of "ren" (仁)—regarding others as one's own body—and "seo" (恕, putting oneself in another's place). On this basis, they toppled the divine right of kings and invented the modern universal human rights premise that "all humans are equal, rational beings capable of empathizing with one another," thereby transforming the West and the entire world. The East itself, meanwhile, failed to realize how cosmic and modern its own Confucian thought was—how capable it was of dismantling the pre-modern order. In other words, true empathy at the dimension of Logos was the most powerful civilizational blueprint for reorganizing human society ethically and horizontally.

Empathy makes it possible for the same words to be received entirely differently depending on the listener's situation. Merely saying "It's okay" to a friend who failed an exam carries a different weight from saying, after listening fully to their

heart, "Next time let's prepare together." Empathy is precisely this power to read the temperature of a relationship.

AI can imitate emotional expression, but the agent that actually carries out responsible empathy is, as yet, the human being. That is why empathy is a human capacity that, the more technology advances, becomes all the more precious.

The third stage, "Gonggam (Empathy, 共感)," refers to the capacity for deep emotional immersion in others, resonance, and the formation of powerful communal bonds. It is the process of drawing out mutual connection and support by understanding and sharing the emotions of others. In the AI era, humans must shift, through a model of the "empathy economy" grounded in the awareness of "I-Here-Now," from isolated "rational actors" into "relational beings" rooted in community. Such an economy prizes the value of connection and of the present moment, and it foregrounds the distinctively human strength in that AI cannot experience genuine empathy. Humans are healed and find meaning through "story and communal connection." Storytelling is itself a "correlative act," one that creates meaning and fosters connection, especially when shared empathically.

A new human ontology sees the human as the "human as connecting being," one who bridges ideas, time, and people. Korea's traditional value of "jeong (情)" can, when combined with modern innovation, point toward a healthier social path. Because AI can imitate emotions but cannot truly "feel" or experience "qualia," the genuine empathic capacity of humans becomes an irreplaceable asset.

"Empathy" is not merely a "soft skill" but functions as a fundamental economic and social organizing principle of the AI era. As AI handles analytical tasks, human labor will increasingly concentrate on empathy-rich activities such as care, connection, and community-building. This signifies a re-evaluation of the "yin (陰)" aspect of the economy and society—that is, relational value—which is at present often undervalued. The success of this "empathy economy" depends on powerful "social capital" such as trust and goodwill.

The act of shared storytelling and narrative construction is a powerful and uniquely human mechanism for creating collective meaning and resilience, and it is indispensable for navigating the anxiety and uncertainty of the AI transition.

Story transforms "isolated, chaotic events" into a "meaningful, coherent sequence." Yet story must be accompanied by the practice of empathy. While AI can generate text, it cannot participate in the shared, embodied, empathic process of meaning-making. The emphasis on "empathy" requires a re-evaluation of leadership and power, demanding a shift from hierarchical command-and-control models to a more relational, empathic, and facilitative style. Leadership grounded in wisdom and empathy becomes important. This stands in contrast to the traditional power structures associated with a credentialist society.

4.2. Confucian (儒教) Logos

We have confirmed that empathy was the hidden driving force behind Western modernization, as well as a powerful tool for shattering artificial standards. Yet the more pluralistic and extremely chaotic the intelligent-information age becomes, the more paradoxically it requires firmer standards of good and evil and transparent social criteria. This is why we must, once again and urgently, summon a cool-headed, ethical Confucian Logos beyond compassionate mercy.

Unlike the two preceding propositions, this statement draws boundaries clearly. It is the attitude of saying that a thing is what it is (X) and what is not is what it is not (-X). This can be understood not as erasing differences, but as a mode of thought that seeks to set each thing rightly in its own place and role.

Taking the school as an example, the responsibility of a teacher and the responsibility of a student differ. Jest among friends and violence also differ, as do help and interference. If we say of everything that it is "all more or less the same," the community instead collapses. Logos emphasizes this ethics of distinction.

Therefore, "X is X, and -X is -X" does not mean exclusivity alone. It means that calling each being by its proper name and role is the starting point of order and respect.

Confucian Logos is a mode of thought that seeks to realize a harmonious social order by rightly establishing the principle (理) and the name/station (名) of things, and by fully discharging the proper way (道) according to each person's role and relationships. Regarding a friend (X) and an enemy (-X), Confucianism, unlike Daoism and Buddhism, says, "X is X, and -X is -X." That is, unlike Daoism, which says the enemy (-X) is a friend (X) and therefore one should love one's enemy, or Buddhism, which says there is neither friend (X) nor enemy (-X), Confucianism holds that a friend is a friend and an enemy is an enemy. The proposition "X is X, and -X is -X" means that each being must be faithful to its own essence and role (X) and must be clearly distinguished from what it is not (-X). In Confucianism, the ruler must be

ruler-like and the subject subject-like; study must be learned and practiced; a friend should come from afar; and one should revere one's own near parents above the distant parents of others. This reflects the rectification-of-names (正名論) perspective, which holds that an orderly and stable community can be achieved when each member of society knows and practices what they ought properly to do from their own position.

4.2.1. Reinterpreting Ren (仁): A New Ethics of Relationship

Ren (仁) is the core of humaneness in Confucianism—put simply, "the heart that regards the other as oneself." Where there is ren, one cannot simply pass by the suffering of another who differs from oneself. This heart is still needed in the AI era—indeed, needed all the more. When an AI algorithm produces a result that disadvantages a particular group, one cannot see the injustice without the sense of ren that asks, "How would it have been had I been in that position?"

When the principle of Logos—that X is X and $\neg X$ is $\neg X$ —is combined with ren (仁), the relational ethics of the AI era is completed: "acknowledge difference, but difference must not become discrimination." Men and women differ ($X \neq \neg X$), the old and the young differ, and persons with and without disabilities differ—yet ensuring that such difference does not lead to unjust discrimination within AI systems is the AI ethics of ren. To apply the sense of ren in the process of designing and reviewing AI systems means to examine outcomes from the standpoint of every person the algorithm affects.

Ren (仁), the core thought of Confucianism, is the essence of humaneness and the foundation of all relational ethics. Ren (仁) is grounded in love and consideration for others—that is, empathy and the heart of compassion (惻隱之心)—and it provides an important guide for establishing a new relational ethics in the AI era, between human and human, and between human and AI. Although AI can imitate human emotions, the true heart of ren (仁)—that is, the ethical subjectivity that empathizes with the suffering of others and voluntarily seeks to do good—is a domain unique to humans. Therefore, the relational ethics of the AI era must clearly distinguish ($X \neq \neg X$) the roles of human (X) and AI ($\neg X$), and must emphasize the ethical responsibility of humans to guide the use of AI in a direction that advances human dignity and the good (善) of the community.

4.2.2. Overcoming the "Han (恨)" of Technological Alienation

Ren (仁), the core thought of Confucianism, advances—in comparing humans with AI—to the concept of han (恨), which is unique to humans alone. Han (恨) is an emotion distinctive to Korea that is difficult to translate simply. It refers not to mere sorrow or anger, but to a deep-seated emotional state in which long-unresolved injustice and longing are intermingled. In the AI era, a new form of han is arising. The benefits of technology are concentrated in the few, while many who cannot keep pace with the speed of the digital transition are left behind amid feelings of alienation and deprivation. Rural elders, older adults unfamiliar with digital devices, and young people doing platform labor as irregular workers—these people bear the new han (恨) of the AI era.

Korean culture possesses the wisdom of resolving han not by simply suppressing it or letting it explode, but through "hanpuri" (the unraveling of han). From the perspective of Hwajaeng, the hanpuri of technological alienation is an institutional effort to invite alienated groups in as participants in the AI era. The expansion of digital education opportunities, intergenerational technology-sharing programs in which elders and youth take part together, and governance in which local communities together choose and make use of AI technology—such practices are the means of unraveling the han of technological alienation through Hwajaeng.

The rapid development of AI technology brings convenience and abundance to some classes, but on the other hand it can give rise to technological alienation through job loss, the deepening of the digital divide, and the like. Such feelings of alienation can leave a deep "han (恨)" in individuals and in society as a whole. The communal thought of Confucianism aims to overcome such technological alienation and to build a community of mutual flourishing (相生) in which all prosper together. This means creating an inclusive social system in which the benefits of AI technological development are distributed evenly across society as a whole, a social safety net is built so that no one is alienated by technology, and every member can participate in the process of technological development and share in its fruits—and this, too, is a domain unique to humans.

The following table presents a comparison of the empathy/postulate theories of Western philosophy (Kant, Hegel) and Eastern thought (Confucius, Buddhism). Kant may be compared with Buddhism, and Hegel with Confucianism.

Table 4-1. Comparison of Western Philosophy (Kant) and Eastern Thought (Buddhism)

Category	Kant (West)	Buddhism (East)
Moral principle	- Emphasis on a sense of duty and rational ought - Does not regard help through compassion as moral - "Postulates" for realizing the highest good (immortality of the soul, freedom, God)	- The thought of Dependent Origination (緣起) and Emptiness (空) - Compassion (慈悲) and non-self (無我) - The interconnectedness of all beings
Concept of empathy	- Emphasis on moral action based on "duty" and "respect" rather than direct "empathy" - "Postulate" as a concept arising from the necessity of practical reason	- A practical attitude of empathizing with others' suffering through "compassion" and seeking to relieve it - Enhanced empathic capacity through understanding that all people are changing beings - Ease of conflict resolution
Implications for the AI era	- Considering the non-emotional nature of AI, the need to explore the limits of human "rational ethics" and transcendent values - The importance of setting a "regulative principle" for the problem of AI's judgmental bias	- Foregrounding the importance of "relational intelligence" and "interdependence" in the AI era - A survival strategy that acknowledges AI's imperfection and works through human "spiritual transcendence" and "inner reflection"

Table 4-2. Comparison of Western Philosophy (Hegel) and Eastern Thought (Confucius)

Category	Hegel (West)	Confucius (East)
Moral principle	- Dialectical self-realization (thesis-antithesis-synthesis) - Views contradiction as the driving force of development - Stages of ethical life (family, civil society, state)	- Emphasis on moral virtues such as ren (仁) and li/propriety (禮) - Self-completion through self-cultivation (修身) - Emphasis on self-reflection and practice

Category	Hegel (West)	Confucius (East)
Concept of empathy	- Overcoming isolated existence through "love," forming a unified self-consciousness of self and other - Reflection on relationship through the dialectical process	- Empathic capacity such as the "heart of compassion" as the core of "ren (仁)" - Possessing a system of projecting the meaning of others through "empathy"
Implications for the AI era	- Understanding the "contradictory relationship" between AI and humans as a "driving force of development" - Emphasis on "holistic" problem-solving capacity through collaboration with AI - The importance of "relational" understanding and "communication" needed for leadership in the AI era	- Re-emphasis on "empathy" and "character education" as the core of "humaneness" in the AI era - Leadership of a "warm heart" and "empathic power" that AI cannot replace

4.3. The Art of Relationship: Beomjeol (凡節)

We have confirmed that Confucian Logos is a universal measure for reconstructing humanity and a framework of ethics. This macroscopic philosophical foundation must not remain empty talk with one's head in the clouds; it must live and breathe as manners and institutions within our concrete daily lives. The practical etiquette and norms of a new era—one in which AI agents and humans will live in daily contact—that is, "beomjeol (凡節)," are now to be newly designed.

Logos connects to beomjeol. This is, in every case, a domain unique to embodied humans. Beomjeol (凡節) refers to the etiquette and norms that keep relationships between people running smoothly. In the AI era, a new form of beomjeol is needed. Whether one must turn on the camera in a video conference, whether one may submit AI-generated writing as one's own, whether one must obtain permission before posting another person's photo on social media—in such new situations, society must together determine what constitutes courteous behavior.

The core of AI etiquette is transparency. Not passing on AI-generated information without verifying its source, and not using AI to manipulate or deceive others—this is the foundation of beomjeol in the AI era. The principle at the heart of Confucian Logos—"call names rightly" (rectification of names, 正名)—remains valid in the AI era as well.

Beomjeol (凡節) refers to etiquette and social norms in everyday life, and it is an essential element for smooth human relationships and harmonious communal living. As AI enters deeply into human life, new norms and etiquette—that is, the "beomjeol of the AI era"—are becoming necessary for interactions between humans and AI as well.

4.3.1. Defining Roles and Responsibilities

In the AI era, not only relationships between humans but also the establishment of relationships between humans and AI emerges as an important task. It is necessary to clearly define the scope of AI's roles and capabilities, as well as where responsibility lies for AI's actions. Humans, as the agents who develop and use AI, must bear ethical responsibility, and AI

must be used in a direction that promotes human welfare under human control and supervision. Furthermore, humans must make efforts to prevent misunderstandings or conflicts that may arise in interactions with AI, and to form healthy relationships grounded in mutual respect and understanding.

4.3.2. Rebuilding Trust: Empathy Capital

Trust is the invisible glue that keeps society running smoothly. When people trust one another, transaction costs fall, cooperation becomes easier, and creative attempts become possible. In the AI era, this trust faces new threats. Fake videos created by deepfakes, false information generated by AI, and biased worldviews produced by algorithms all have the power to undermine the trust between people. Rebuilding trust is one of the most urgent social tasks of the AI era.

Empathy capital is a social asset accumulated through the capacity for empathy. The memory of having been helped when in difficulty, the experience of having had one's heart truly understood, the history of having weathered hardship together—these form empathy capital. Like money saved in a bank, this capital is invisible, yet it is the real power that enables a community to endure together in a moment of crisis. If AI can raise efficiency and speed, empathy capital is the distinctively human capacity for recovery that mends the social fractures AI creates.

Cultivating empathy capital at school is possible even without special programs. Listening sincerely to a friend's presentation, consciously including a friend who has been left out, and first hearing out one another's positions when a conflict arises—these small practices build empathy capital. This later becomes the foundation for creating a truly humane organization when working alongside AI in society.

The development of AI technology offers convenience, but at the same time it carries risk factors that can undermine social trust, such as invasion of personal information, algorithmic bias, and the spread of false information. Therefore, in the AI era, it is important to rebuild a healthy trust grounded in critical thinking rather than blind trust in technology. To this end, we must enhance the transparency and explainability of AI systems, adhere to ethical principles in the process of developing and using AI, and establish social oversight and regulation to prevent the misuse of technology.

Furthermore, we must accumulate "empathy capital" grounded in the distinctively human capacity for empathy, and through it promote mutual understanding and cooperation so as to strengthen the foundation of social trust.

4.4. Yokdae (浴帶) and the Discernment of Good and Evil: The Final Line of Defense Distinguishing AI from Humans

In the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages, the human who has come into the world through "yangsaeng" inevitably meets the stage of "yokdae (浴帶)." Yokdae literally means "to bathe and gird oneself with a sash," and it signifies, beyond merely covering the body, the establishment of an ethical identity that puts on the garment of social norms and begins to distinguish the good and evil (善惡) of the world.

It is precisely this characteristic of "yokdae" that is the core of the empathy toward which Confucian Logos aims. Empathy, beyond simply weeping together, is the act of weightily judging—within the web of relationships—what is right and what leads humanity to ruin (good and evil). Artificial intelligence (AI), on the basis of humanity's enormous data, can "output" sorrowful sentences in tune with the sound of weeping. Yet because AI does not possess the substantive body of suffering (yangsaeng), it cannot undergo the process of "yokdae"—of bathing and purifying oneself and girding on the ethical sash (the bone-deep embodiment of good and evil). In the coming age of extremes, the sole and most powerful practical weapon capable of distinguishing and controlling soulless machine algorithms from humans is precisely "the capacity to discern good and evil through empathy."

From the perspective of Hwajaeng, the establishment of identity is not "choosing a single real self." Rather, it is discovering, while acknowledging the many faces of oneself, a core value that does not waver in any situation. The self that laughs together with friends is me, the self that agonizes alone is me, and the self that receives AI's help is me—but what one holds important when making a choice, that value system, is the true center of identity. Finding this center is the most important developmental task of young people in the AI era.

Yokdae (浴帶), in the Eastern stages of human development, refers to the period of first stepping into society and, within relationships with others, testing and establishing one's own identity. Individuals in the AI era must form their identity within a complex social environment where the virtual and the real are intermingled and diverse information and value systems collide. What matters in this process is forging social relationships through genuine empathy and communication with others, and finding one's role and meaning within the community. We must recognize that while AI can be a tool for access to information and for communication, genuine socialization and the establishment of identity are achieved through human interaction and experience.

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

5. The Fourth Method of Correlative Thinking – Yunghap (Convergence, 融合)

Theos: X is everything ($\forall X$)

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

5. The Fourth Method of Correlative Thinking – Yunghap (Convergence, 融合)

5.1. The Definition of Convergent Thinking

In Chapter 4, we made clear that "empathy" through Logos is not mere emotional sympathizing, but a powerful, distinctively human measure for discerning the social norms and the good and evil of the age. Humanity, having sought roots (mimesis), forged relationships (mythos), and established order (logos), now stands before the final stage of evolution. Beyond analyzing and discerning, a great integration is required—one that, at the cosmic dimension, thoroughly blends East and West, machine (AI) and human civilization as a whole into one and weaves a new framework. This is the reason the thinking of Yunghap (Convergence, 融合)—the completion of the four modes of correlative thinking—appears in Chapter 4.

Convergence is not the work of recklessly mixing this and that. It is the work of drawing out the strengths of different elements to create a new order that did not exist before. It is easily understood by thinking of bibimbap. The mixing of ingredients does not cause each individual flavor to disappear; rather, the overall taste becomes richer.

The same holds for scholarship. Philosophy alone cannot solve all technological problems, and engineering alone cannot solve all ethical problems. History and religion, economics and science, and the arts must meet in order to properly address the complex problems of the AI era.

To use the analogy of a middle school student's studies, convergence is solving a single problem by using together the reading comprehension of Korean language, the understanding of institutions in social studies, and the analytical capacity of science. This is because real-life problems always overlap across several subjects.

The fourth stage, "Yunghap (Convergence, 融合)," means creatively synthesizing diverse elements—ideas, cultures, methodologies, even the capacities of humans and machines—to produce something new and more powerful. This embodies the principle of "Consilience." One of the core themes is aiming at the "hybrid thinker" by integrating the

East's holistic wisdom (correlative thinking) with the West's analytical rationality. "Liminal spaces"—transitional, in-between states in which ordinary rules are suspended—are fertile soil for the emergence of "creativity, flexibility, connection" and new synthesis. AI itself is leading society into such a liminal stage. Korea's popular-culture phenomenon, the "Korean Wave (Hallyu)," is presented as an example of successful cultural "convergence" that blended local and foreign elements to create something new and globally resonant. Korea's "bibim" (mixing) culture is also likened to a "yin-yang convergence" that offers ethical and creative insight.

As concrete methodologies of convergence, "Structurology" integrates heterogeneous fields of mathematics into a coherent system and seeks to understand phenomena through fundamental structures of connection (Kim Dong-ryeol 2010); "TRIZ" is a systematic problem-solving methodology that synthesizes principles from diverse fields to generate innovative solutions (Kim Ho-jong et al. 2011); and "Human Design" is presented as a system that integrates ancient wisdom (the I Ching, Kabbalah, the chakras) with modern science (genetics, physics) to explain the uniqueness of the individual (Krakower 2018). The ultimate goal is the convergence of human and machine—a "new human-AI co-evolution."

"Convergence" is a process that, beyond merely mixing existing elements, creates emergent properties transcending the sum of the parts and new solutions. This is especially important in the AI era, which faces unprecedented challenges. The discussion of liminal spaces suggests that truly new forms emerge in these "in-between-and-between" spaces. Methodologies such as TRIZ and Human Design are not mere collections of ideas but frameworks for generating new insight through synthesis. This means that in the AI era, human creativity will increasingly lie in "creative connectivity"—the fusing of diverse domains of knowledge, including knowledge that AI can generate, into a new and valuable whole.

The success of cultural convergence such as the Korean Wave provides a model by which a society can navigate globalization and technological change—not by resisting outside influences or losing its identity, but rather by integrating them creatively. This is "convergence" as a civilizational strategy. The demand for "convergence" implies the

need to break down the barriers between traditional academic disciplines in education and research, and to foster more interdisciplinary and transdisciplinary approaches so that humans can prepare for a complex future. If "hybrid thinkers" are needed, then the education system must change to foster them. The following table summarizes the diverse methodologies that embody the principle of "convergence" in the AI era.

Table 5: Methodologies of "Yunghap (Convergence, 融合)" in the AI Era

Methodology	Core principle	Application in the AI era
Correlative Thinking	Holistic, relational, contextual understanding	Ethical governance of AI, design of human-AI interaction, sustainable management of complex socio-technical systems
Liminality Exploration	Creativity, flexibility, and the emergence of new synthesis in transitional spaces	Managing social and occupational transitions caused by AI adoption, designing new norms and institutions, experimenting with human-AI collaboration models
Structurology	Exploring regularities of connection among separated elements, integrating diverse fields into a coherent logical system, and emphasizing the form in which information is conveyed	Understanding the internal operating principles of complex AI systems, optimizing data structures and information flow, and enhancing the stability and predictability of AI-based systems
TRIZ	Systematic problem-solving and innovation through resolving contradictions, applying inventive principles, and pursuing the Ideal Final Result (IFR)	Overcoming the limits of AI algorithms, pioneering new fields of AI application, solving unexpected problems in AI technology, and developing innovative solutions through human-AI collaboration
Human Design	Understanding an individual's unique energy flow, potential, and decision-making style through the integration of ancient wisdom and modern science	Redefining individual strengths and roles in the AI era, personalized education and career development, optimizing complementarity when forming human-AI teams, and enhancing individual well-being

Methodology	Core principle	Application in the AI era
"Bibim" (Mixing) Culture	Creating new values and identities through the harmonious blending of diverse elements (local/foreign, traditional/modern)	Creative combination of global AI technology with local culture, cultural contextualization of AI ethics and policy, and developing AI solutions through collaboration among teams of diverse backgrounds

5.2. The Fourth Thought: $\forall X$, Theos

It grasped the infinite power of convergence (Yunghap) that breaks down boundaries and forges entirely new cosmic values. If stereoscopic thinking (Ipche), cyclical thinking (Sunhwan), and empathy (Gonggam) each sought the roots of life, formed relationships, and established order, it is now time for a great crucible to appear—one that melts all of this thinking into a single whole and sublimates it into a new galaxy. That is precisely Theos, the all-embracing "Fourth Thought" that this era has so urgently awaited.

The Abrahamic religions (Christianity, Catholicism, Islam), which hold that "X is everything," pursue the eternal life of the soul (靈魂永生) through a covenantal cycle grounded in the Ten Commandments between God and the human community. Because the Ten Commandments and the Lord's Prayer encompass all of Heaven, Earth, and Humanity—corresponding to matter, spirit, and being—"X is everything" holds true. Since the logic of "X is everything" leads one to pursue the community over the individual and the spirit over matter, it comes to seek eternal life through the soul.

This expression does not mean that all boundaries completely disappear, but rather that each being is connected within a larger whole. A person is part of a family, part of a school community, and also part of society and history. What it captures is the sense that the small individual is not severed from the great whole.

Put simply, a single piece of trash I discard is connected to environmental problems, and a single comment I post is connected to someone's day. My choices do not end with me alone. In this sense, "X is everything" is also a statement of immense responsibility.

In the AI era, this way of thinking matters even more, because a single company's algorithm, a single nation's technology policy, and a single individual's usage habits all affect the trust and safety of the entire world.

As the Fourth Thought, "X is everything ($\forall X$)" can be linked to a pantheistic perspective, embodying the insight that all beings are fundamentally connected as one and that individual things are diverse manifestations of the whole. This suggests the possibility that everything may interpenetrate and converge, transcending the dichotomous boundaries between part and whole, subject and object, human and nature, and further between human and machine. In the AI era, such thinking can open a new ontological horizon beyond anthropocentrism.

5.2.1. The Dissolution of the Academic-Credentialist Society and the Shift of Power

A representative domain among these new horizons is the academic-credentialist society. Existing fields disappear and new ones emerge. The era in which one's life was determined by college entrance exams is increasingly being shaken by AI. What one can actually do is becoming more important than the fact of having graduated from a particular prestigious university. AI has democratized access to information. Knowledge that once could be obtained only through excellent professors or expensive textbooks is now open to anyone through online lectures and AI tools. This is becoming a force that accelerates the cracking of the academic-credential monopoly.

This change, however, does not automatically create an equal society, because the very ability to make good use of AI can become a new privilege. Those who have difficulty accessing computers and the internet, those who cannot afford to learn AI tools, and non-English speakers who cannot fully utilize English-based AI due to the digital language gap—these people risk becoming a new class of the digitally marginalized. Seen through the eyes of Hwajaeng (Reconciliation of Disputes), even after the dissolution of the academic-credentialist society, power does not disappear but merely changes form and shifts. What matters is consciously designing that new power structure to be fairer and more open.

The advancement of AI technology is fundamentally transforming the ways knowledge is produced, distributed, and accessed, dismantling the foundations of the traditional academic-credentialist society. The power once maintained through the monopoly of knowledge and information is losing its force as AI makes such knowledge universally accessible. From the perspective of "X is everything," knowledge and wisdom are not confined to particular classes or institutions but exist everywhere in diverse forms, and AI can play the role of connecting and amplifying this dispersed

wisdom. Accordingly, power shifts away from past academic credentials or status toward the ability to converge diverse knowledge, create new value, and offer solutions to complex problems.

5.2.2. The Convergence of East and West and of Human and Machine

The true wisdom of the AI era can emerge when the East's mimetic (complementary, imitative) thinking and mythic (narrative, symbolic) thinking, together with the West's logical (analytical) thinking, converge with human experiential wisdom and machine data-based intelligence. The perspective of "X is everything" shows that these diverse systems of thought and forms of wisdom are not mutually exclusive but can be integrated in a complementary manner. The following table presents cases and characteristics of East-West resonance applicable in the AI era.

Table 6: Methodologies of "East-West Resonance" in the AI Era

Eastern Resonance	Western Resonance
Yin-Yang and the Five Phases, Dependent Origination, the Doctrine of the Mean	Systems theory, complexity science, ecology
Wuji (無極, the Limitless), Xu (虛, Emptiness), the Middle Way (中道)	Rites of Passage studies; the early stage of "disruptive innovation" in innovation theory
Pattern recognition in the Hetu and Luoshu, the interactive structure of the Five Phases	Topology, network theory, systems architecture
Strategic thinking in Sunzi's Art of War (overcoming contradictions), application of the principles of change in the I Ching (Yi)	Invention studies, engineering design methodology, Creative Problem Solving (CPS)
The I Ching, the chakra system, elements of Myeongni (fortune-reading) studies	Genetics, quantum physics, biochemical individuality
Harmony of Yin and Yang, harmony without uniformity (和而不同)	Cultural Fusion, hybrid innovation

Humans can use AI's analytical capabilities to reinterpret Eastern wisdom in modern terms, while at the same time drawing on Eastern insight to guide the ethical and humane development of AI technology. Such convergent wisdom will

be the core driving force behind solving the complex problems of the AI era and creating a new civilization.

5.3. A New Image of the Human: Gwanwang and Dosol

Gwanwang (冠旺) is the stage that arrives after Yokdae among the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages of Myeongni studies; it signifies the peak period in which one dons the cap (冠) and one's energy becomes flourishing (旺). In this book, in keeping with that meaning, it denotes a mature adult and autonomous conductor who embraces and "commands" (統率) all the preceding stages of Potae (potentiality), Yangsaeng (embodiment), and Yokdae (ethical discernment).

Gwanwang (冠旺) is the symbol of a figure who orchestrates complex situations with outstanding wisdom and judgment. This is not merely someone who possesses much knowledge or superior skill, but someone with the wisdom to recognize the abilities of different people and let each shine in their own place. The core role required of the human being in the AI era is precisely this image of Gwanwang. AI is a powerful instrument, but an instrument alone does not make music. A human like Gwanwang must decide for which piece, at what intensity, and within what harmony the instrument that is AI shall be played.

To put it in an analogy familiar to a middle-school student, Gwanwang is like an excellent team leader or class president—someone who does not pretend to be good at everything, but recognizes what each team member does best, distributes roles accordingly, and resolves conflicts fairly when they arise. In the AI era, such a person is also the one who makes the best use of AI. The ability to judge what tasks to entrust to AI, what tasks humans must do, and how to review AI's outputs is the contemporary role of Gwanwang.

Into what kind of being must the human be reborn in the AI era? The analogy of "Gwanwang (冠旺)" and "Dosol (兜率)" offers one answer to this question.

5.3.1. The Human as Gwanwang (冠旺)

An AI agent is an AI program that autonomously carries out specific tasks. In the near future, an era will come in which dozens of AI agents work simultaneously for individuals, for companies, and for governments. Information-gathering agents, scheduling agents, customer-service agents, and decision-support agents will all operate at once. To make proper use of this complex legion of agents, the orchestrating ability of a human like Gwanwang is required. Which agent to assign which task, how to coordinate agents when they conflict with one another, and how to verify agents' outputs—all these judgments fall to the human.

For Gwanwang's leadership to function effectively, two capacities are needed. The first is to know precisely the capabilities and limits of AI. If one cannot distinguish what an agent does well from what it does poorly, one ends up assigning the wrong task to the wrong agent. The second is the attitude of taking ultimate human responsibility for the results AI produces. No matter how good an agent's output, responsibility for that output's impact on people ultimately rests with people. This sense of responsibility is the core that safeguards the human as Gwanwang in the AI era.

Gwanwang symbolizes the image of a leader who orchestrates and guides complex situations with outstanding wisdom and insight. Like the conductor of an orchestra, the human in the AI era must perform the role of "Gwanwang," harmoniously orchestrating countless AI agents and automated systems and leading them toward a common goal. This demands, beyond merely controlling AI, a high order of wisdom and judgment that maximizes AI's potential while preventing ethical problems and realizing human-centered values.

5.3.2. The Realization of Tusita Heaven (兜率天)

Dosol (兜率) is the transliteration of Tusita, the ideal realm Dosolcheon (Tusita Heaven) where Maitreya, the future Buddha, dwells in the Buddhist cosmology. In this book, beyond its original spatial meaning, it is deliberately given a homophonic and ideational connotation—that of binding countless artificial-intelligence agents into one and leading and "commanding" (統率) them all. Since this accords with the image of Gwanwang, it is used as one connected part of the process of human growth.

Tusita Heaven is, in Buddhism, the ideal world where Maitreya dwells—a Pure Land brimming with wisdom and compassion. In the AI era, "Tusita Heaven" can serve as a metaphor for an ideal state in which human will and creativity can be infinitely expanded and realized through the AI network. By making AI a tool and partner for realizing one's own will, the human can unfold creative activity beyond individual limits and, going further, be reborn as an "expanded human" contributing to the welfare and development of society as a whole. This is an image of a future society that can be built through the harmonious coexistence of technology and humanity.

5.4. The Final Stage of Completion: Convergence

We can envision a truly mature image of the human, advancing toward the grand ideal of Tusita Heaven under the direction of Gwanwang (the commander). Humanity, having passed narratively through Potae, Yangsaeng, and Yokdae, at last comes to wield cosmic command with ease. Now the moment of "convergence (Yunghap)"—the final knot of this majestic and sacred grand journey of thought, and the ultimate goal that a hyperconnected civilization must reach—arrives before us.

Seeing stereoscopically, reading cyclically, connecting through empathy, and finally creating something new through convergence. When these four stages are completed, the human becomes not a mere user of AI but a designer of the civilization of the AI era. The word "completer" may sound grandiose, but its essence is simple: it means that the human is a being who does not simply accept the world AI has made, but chooses and takes responsibility for what kind of world to create.

The most important task for the human as completer in a hyperconnected society is to ask "good questions." AI quickly produces answers to questions, but which questions are important is something humans must decide. Just as this entire paper began from one great question—"How can humanity survive together in the AI era?"—future generations too must pose the large and important questions suited to their own times. Correlative thinking and the wisdom of Hwajaeng are the most humane training for cultivating the power of such questions.

Convergence, the final stage of correlative thinking, means that the human, drawing on the insights and capacities gained through stereoscopic thinking, cyclical thinking, and empathy, performs the role of an autonomous "completer" in the hyperconnected AI society. This goes beyond merely adapting to technology; it is the process of actively utilizing technology in accordance with human values and purposes, and creating a new civilizational ecosystem in which humans and AI develop together. Through convergent thinking, humans will build an order of symbiosis and harmony that

transcends division and conflict, becoming the creative protagonists who lead the infinite possibilities of the AI era toward the prosperity of all humanity.

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

6. Conclusion to Part I: A Strategy of Correlative Thinking

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

6. Conclusion to Part I: A Strategy of Correlative Thinking

On the vast silk tapestry of history, the AI revolution is like a new thread—glimmering with hope while also carrying the threat of unraveling existing patterns. To weave this thread in harmony, humanity must remember the skill of the master weaver: one who sees the entire design, understands the color and role of each thread, and possesses the patience and creativity to make adjustments when the pattern goes awry. In other words, we must take correlative thinking—that is, relational and holistic thinking—as our fundamental strategy.

6.1. The Organic Consilience of the Four Modes of Thinking

The four modes of correlative thinking are not tools used separately but an engine that turns together. When stereoscopic thinking lets us see reality from multiple angles, cyclical thinking lets us read the flow of time within those multiple angles, empathy lets us connect the hearts of the people within that flow, and convergence combines all of this into new value. If any one is missing, the rest cannot function fully either. Without seeing relationships stereoscopically, the depth of empathy becomes shallow; without knowing the rhythm of the cycle, one misses the timing of convergence.

Consider the analogy of a school project. Examining the topic from many perspectives when first choosing it is stereoscopic thinking; the process of gathering material, discarding it, and reorganizing it again is cyclical thinking; coordinating and encouraging the opinions of group members is empathy; and turning each person's output into one completed presentation is convergence. In the AI era, training in these four is a way of building individual competitiveness, but beyond that, it is also a way of cultivating a civilization's capacity to transform conflict into Hwajaeng.

The four-stage methodology presented in this text—stereoscopic thinking (Ipche, Mimesis), cyclical thinking (Sunhwan, Mythos), empathy (Gonggam, Logos), and convergence (Yunghap, Theos)—constitutes, on the basis of correlative thinking, a coherent strategy that contributes to human adaptation and flourishing in the AI era. Each stage is interconnected and generates synergy: "stereoscopic" understanding influences the way we recognize "cyclical" patterns, and "empathy" becomes an essential condition for meaningful "convergence." This multidimensional approach lays a foundation on which humans can complement AI's analytical capabilities, respond flexibly amid unpredictable change, and guide technology to align with human-centered values. Daoist mimesis, through the principle of complementarity, offers the harmonious coexistence of AI and humanity; Buddhist mythos, through the thought of Dependent Origination and Emptiness, offers the wisdom of relational becoming; Confucian logos, grounded in Ren (benevolence), offers a new

ethics of relationship; and convergence, as the Fourth Thought, embraces all of these and points the way to the creation of new value.

6.2. Toward a New Renaissance

In an AI-driven world, human correlative capacities such as empathy, holistic understanding, ethical judgment, meaning-making, and creative synthesis are distinctively human strengths whose value only rises as AI handles routine analytical tasks. The AI era paradoxically demands of us that we "cherish what makes humans human—namely, holistic intelligence—and organize society accordingly." This is a path that opens a new horizon in the AI era not through competition with machines but through the deepening and manifestation of human uniqueness. AI is a powerful tool, but it cannot be an end in itself. Humans must use AI as a means to realize the ultimate purposes of human dignity, happiness, and the prosperity of the community. This means guarding against technological absolutism, restoring human-centered values, and aspiring to a new Renaissance that humans and AI will create together.

6.3. Approaches to Education and Social Practice

Correlative thinking is not a difficult and complex Eastern philosophy but a concrete habit of thought that can be practiced in real life. In the educational setting, the best way to cultivate correlative thinking is training that asks "why" and "how" together. The starting point of correlative thinking is the habit of considering, rather than simply finding the correct answer, why something is a problem, how it looks from other perspectives, and whom the solution affects and in what way.

At the level of social practice, creating spaces for "slow dialogue" is important. The AI era demands fast information and immediate responses, but correlative thinking and Hwajaeng grow out of "slow dialogue" that takes ample time to understand one another. Only when institutional spaces for such "slow dialogue"—community discussion groups, philosophy classes in schools, corporate ethics discussion sessions, and government public-deliberation processes—remain alive even in the AI era does the practice of Hwajaeng become possible.

AI companies and platforms can also take part in the practice of correlative thinking. Including users of diverse cultures, ages, and income levels when designing AI systems, regularly reviewing and disclosing algorithmic bias, and providing content that educates users to use AI critically—all of these are corporate-level practices of correlative thinking. Companies that invest in designing their relationships with people as much as in the speed of technological development will become the true leading enterprises of the AI era.

The manifestation of these human attributes does not come about on its own. It requires conscious effort through education, policy-making, cultural development, and personal practice. Humans must move beyond being mere "problem solvers" to perform the role of "meaning solvers" amid a complex world and technology. This will be the core driving force that enables humans to develop without losing their agency in the AI era, harmonizing technology with human values.

Educational innovation: We must move away from memorization-centered education toward education that cultivates correlative thinking capacities such as critical thinking, creative problem-solving ability, empathy, and collaboration skills.

Redesigning social systems: We must build inclusive social systems so that the benefits of technological development are shared across society as a whole and so that no marginalization arises from technology. A process of establishing AI ethical standards and reaching social consensus on the development and use of AI technology is necessary.

Cultural reflection and practice: Through ceaseless self-reflection and learning, individuals must adapt to a changing era, and within their communities they must stand in solidarity with others and pursue a meaningful life. Effort is needed to apply correlative thinking to daily life and work.

The integration of Eastern wisdom and Western rationality, and of human ability and AI tools, foretells the emergence of a new kind of human—one technically proficient yet possessed of deep wisdom—namely the "wise cyborg" or "hybrid thinker." The Hallyu (Korean Wave) phenomenon can be seen as one example of such a successful strategy of synthesis, and "Hallyu as a new-human strategy of stereoscopic thinking, cyclical thinking, and empathy" implies the possibilities that cultural convergence presents.

Ultimately, what distinguishes and guides us in the AI-driven hyperconnected world is the uniquely human capacity for holistic, interconnected reasoning, reinforced by bodily presence and intuition. Just as Yin and Yang taught that manifest opposites can form a larger whole, human intuition and artificial intelligence too, if approached wisely, can form a partnership greater than the sum of its parts. Just as the Five Phases remind us that balance and cyclical renewal are the key to longevity, we must maintain a balance between technological advancement and ethical, emotional, and cultural renewal. The stories and contingencies of life remind us that we are not the objects of algorithms but the subjects of our own destiny. If we remember that we are the ultimate connectors, we need not fear the hyperconnected future.

"The silk of civilization will surely take on new patterns, yet it will still be woven by human hands, according to wisdom born of long-standing hypothesis and imagination—a true triumph of hypothesis and imagination that the two have

created together." By thinking within the whole and within relationships, feeling deeply, creating boldly, and acting according to conscience, humans will be able not merely to survive in the AI era but to blossom within it.

II. Applications: Hwajaeng Theory and the Symbiotic Economy

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

7. Four-Gate (Sammun) Hwajaeng and the Four Modes of Correlative Thinking

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

7. Four-Gate (Sammun) Hwajaeng and the Four Modes of Correlative Thinking

The four modes of correlative thinking examined in Part I—stereoscopic thinking (Ipche, 立體), cyclical thinking (Sunhwan, 循環), empathy (Gonggam, 共感), and convergence (Yunghap, 融合)—form a remarkable structural correspondence with the historical unfolding of Buddhist Hwajaeng thought. The Hwajaeng (和諍) thought of Wonhyo (元曉, 617–686), beginning from the opposition of two terms (二項) and expanding into three-term (三項) and four-term (四項) relations, exhibits at each stage a philosophical structure that corresponds precisely to the laws of correlative thinking in Part I. (Kim Sang-il 2003)

7.1. The Starting Point of Two-Term (二項) Hwajaeng: The Suchness Gate (Madhyamaka) and the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate (Yogacara) → Linkage with Stereoscopic Thinking (Mimesis)

The two-term structure denotes a configuration of two standing face to face. The Suchness Gate can be understood to point to the dimension of essence, and the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate to the dimension of change. Put simply, one sees the deep ground, while the other sees the movement manifest before one's eyes.

Translated into a student's daily life, it resembles the relationship between school rules and the actual scene of the classroom. Looking only at the rules, the principles are visible but the complexity of reality is hard to see; looking only at the real scene, it is easy to lose direction. The Suchness Gate and the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate let us see these two dimensions together.

Herein lies the reason two-term Hwajaeng connects with stereoscopic thinking: when two different perspectives are set up simultaneously, the depth of reality becomes visible.

In the system of the Awakening of Faith in the Mahayana (大乘起信論), the starting point of Wonhyo's Hwajaeng is the two-term (二項) relationship of the Suchness Gate (眞如門) and the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate (生滅門). The Suchness Gate, as the essence of the mind, deals with the aspect of empty, quiescent numinous awareness (空寂靈知) and corresponds to Madhyamaka (Middle Way) thought. The Arising-and-Ceasing Gate deals with the changes of the phenomenal world and the workings centered on the alaya-consciousness (阿賴耶識), and corresponds to Yogacara thought.

The Master Wonhyo integrated these into the One Mind and Two Gates (一心二門). If the Suchness Gate is essence (體)—the essential aspect—then the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate is function (用)—the phenomenal working.

Linkage with Stereoscopic Thinking (Mimesis) in Chapter 2 of Part I: The two-term Hwajaeng of the Suchness Gate and the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate corresponds precisely to the logical structure of Daoist mimesis. The Emptiness (空) of Madhyamaka and the consciousness (識) of Yogacara negate each other yet are subsumed as one within the One Mind (一心).

7.2. The Deepening of Three-Term (三項) Hwajaeng:

The three-term structure is one in which a single mediation enters between the two. It resembles how, when two friends quarrel, the entry of a third perspective makes the structure of the quarrel appear anew. When there are only two, it is a fight over right and wrong, but when a third perspective enters, the relationship begins to move.

The Three-Natures doctrine does not fix the world all at once but views it by distinguishing the level of discrimination, the level of relation, and the level of completion. It thus functions like a staircase on which thought matures one step at a time.

In this respect, three-term Hwajaeng connects well with cyclical thinking, because a movement toward deeper understanding arises as one goes back and forth between the two extremes.

The developed Three-Natures doctrine (三性說) of Yogacara thought is a sophisticated philosophical tool that expands the existing two-term Hwajaeng of Madhyamaka and Yogacara into a three-term (三項) relationship. The Three Natures consist of the imagined nature (遍計所執性), the dependent nature (依他起性), and the perfected nature (圓成實性).

The core insight of the Three-Natures doctrine is the proposition that "when the imagined nature is removed upon the dependent nature, that itself is the perfected nature."

The following table presents the transformation of the two-term relationship of the Suchness Gate and the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate into a three-term relationship.

Table 7.1 The Binary Relationship between the Suchness Gate and the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate

Category	Suchness Gate (Jinyeo-mun, 眞如門)	Arising-and-Ceasing Gate (Saengmyeol-mun, 生滅門)
Philosophical Attitude	Essence (che, 體) — the essential aspect	Function (yong, 用) — the phenomenal operation
Principal School	Madhyamaka (Middle Way, 中觀)	Yogacara (Consciousness-only, 唯識)
Core Concept	Refuting the false (pasa, 破邪) — breaking mistaken views	Revealing the true (hyeonjeong, 顯正) — disclosing correct principle
Character	Absolute equality (emptiness)	Relative differentiation (following conditions)

Table 7.2 Transformation of the Suchness Gate and the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate into a Ternary Relationship

Existing Two-Fold Hwajaeng (Awakening of Faith)	Expanded Hwajaeng Based on the Yogacara Three Natures	Logic of Hwajaeng
Suchness Gate (Jinyeo, 眞如)	Perfected Nature (wonseongsilseong, 圓成實性)	Absolute truth (full even while empty)
Arising-and-Ceasing Gate (Saengmyeol, 生滅)	Dependent Nature (uitagiseong, 依他起性)	Phenomenal dependent origination (appearance according to conditions)
(Subordinate to the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate)	Imagined Nature (byeongyesojipseong, 遍計所執性)	Subjective delusion (the object to be broken down)

Examining its connection with Part 1, Chapter 2, "Cyclical Thinking (Mythos)," the ternary Hwajaeng structure of the Three-Natures doctrine corresponds to the logic of the Buddhist Mythos. The Dependent Nature cyclically mediates between the Imagined Nature and the Perfected Nature, thereby overcoming both nihilism and substantialism at once.

7.3. The Completion of Four-Gate (Sahang) Hwajaeng:

The four-gate structure is a mode of thinking that views four directions together. It is not merely looking forward and backward but like a map that takes in north, south, east, and west at once. With the addition of the Pure Land Gate, Hwajaeng transcends a mere analytical system and comes to embrace even the sense of salvation on which human beings can actually rely and live.

The following table shows the transformation of Hwajaeng, fused with the Pure Land Gate, into a quaternary relationship.

Table 8: Transformation of Hwajaeng Fused with the Pure Land Gate into a Quaternary Relationship

Name	Core Character	Seasonal Correlation	Role in Hwajaeng
Suchness Gate (Jinyeo-mun, 眞如門)	Absolute emptying (Madhyamaka)	Autumn	Return to essence (refuting phenomena)
Arising-and-Ceasing Gate (Saengmyeol-mun, 生滅門)	Arising of phenomena (Awakening of Faith)	Spring	Understanding phenomena (representation)
Three-Natures Gate (Samseong-mun, 三性門)	Analysis of existence (Yogacara)	Summer	Distinguishing the false from the true
Pure Land Gate (Jeongto-mun, 淨土門)	Salvation through compassion (Pure Land school)	Winter	Practical taking-refuge and rest

What matters is that the four gates are not separate rooms warring with one another. Each is a different door through which human beings understand the world, and whichever door one enters, all ultimately meet within a larger house.

The connection with empathic thinking also becomes apparent here. Empathy (Gonggam) is not simply imitating the other; it is the attitude of acknowledging that beyond the door one has entered, other doors also exist.

Establishing the Pure Land school (淨土宗) as an independent gate (門) and thereby expanding the structure of Hwajaeng into four gates (四門) is a highly warranted endeavor in reinterpreting the thought of Master Wonhyo for the modern age.

The oppositional structure of the four gates consists of two axes facing each other. The vertical opposition: the Suchness Gate and the Pure Land Gate face each other. The horizontal opposition: the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate and the Three-Natures Gate face each other. Wonhyo resolves this through the logic of opening and merging (gaehap, 開合)—unfolded they are four, yet merged they are one.

7.4. Spring, Summer, Autumn, and Winter:

The analogy of the four seasons makes Hwajaeng easiest to understand. Just as one cannot say that spring alone is a good season while winter is useless, the four gates of thought each assume a different role. Only when the functions of beginning, growth, reflection, and storage are all present does the whole of life continue.

Our society tends to cling to and live within one particular season. For example, if only growth and speed are emphasized, it becomes a society of perpetual summer, and as a result people grow exhausted and the community withers. Hwajaeng compels us to ask, "In which season is our society now confined?"

Convergent thinking (Yunghap) reads these four seasons as a single grand rhythm. When we understand that the different stages do not collide but revolve in sequence, conflict becomes a matter not of destruction but of rearrangement. The following table shows the relationship between spring, summer, autumn, and winter and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng.

Table 9: The Relationship between Spring, Summer, Autumn, and Winter and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng

Season	Gate (門)	Associated Thought	Essence of Hwajaeng
Spring	Arising-and-Ceasing Gate	Huayan	Just as the universe is contained in a single flower (one-is-many), arising-and-ceasing phenomena are themselves truth
Summer	Three-Natures Gate	Seon (Chan)	The intensity of cutting through delusion (the Imagined) with a single stroke to intuit the essence (the Perfected)

Season	Gate (門)	Associated Thought	Essence of Hwajaeng
Autumn	Suchness Gate	Tathagatagarbha	Peeling away every shell to confirm the pure seed of Buddhahood within
Winter	Pure Land Gate	Pure Land	Holding the seed and resting in the vast embrace of compassion, preparing new life

The dynamic meaning of the Four-Gate (四門) Hwajaeng becomes all the more vivid when it is arranged in the cyclical order of spring, summer, autumn, and winter.

[Spring (春) — Arising-and-Ceasing Gate] The beginning of life, in which the myriad dharmas sprout from the alaya-consciousness according to conditions. "When the mind arises, all manner of dharmas arise (心生即種種法生)."

[Summer (夏) — Three-Natures Gate] The period of practicing intensely in accordance with the law of conditions (the Dependent Nature), discerning the fruit (the Perfected) from the weeds (the Imagined).

[Autumn (秋) — Suchness Gate] The stage of quiet convergence, in which one sets down all phenomena (arising-and-ceasing) and all discrimination (the three natures) and returns to emptiness (sunyata, 空), the empty essence.

[Winter (冬) — Pure Land Gate] The rest and vow in which one acknowledges that one's own power is exhausted, immerses oneself completely in the vow-power of Amitabha Buddha, and prepares to be reborn.

The arising of spring (arising-and-ceasing) faces the vanishing of autumn (suchness), and the intense analysis of summer (three natures) faces the unconditional acceptance of winter (Pure Land).

7.5. The Grand Integration of Tathagatagarbha, Pure Land, Huayan, and Seon:

This section is difficult because it involves so many names, but its core is single: different traditions ultimately employ different vocabularies to address how they understand the potential within the human being and the affirmativeness of the world.

Some traditions emphasize an original luminosity, some emphasize a world of salvation, and still others emphasize a vast web of relations in which everything is interconnected. Though their expressions differ, together they affirm that the human being is not a being cast solely toward despair.

Hwajaeng is precisely the work of reading this common ground. It is a philosophy that reveals that difference of name does not mean utter severance, and that even within difference there is a continuing center.

Tathagatagarbha (如來藏), Pure Land (淨土), Huayan (華嚴), and Seon (禪宗) share the radiant world of affirmation reached at the end of the analyses of Madhyamaka and Yogacara. The greatest commonality among these four schools of thought is the logic of original enlightenment (bongak, 本覺, being originally enlightened).

Tathagatagarbha and Pure Land are like two sides of the same coin. Wonhyo said, "The Pure Land is none other than the pure mind (Tathagatagarbha)," yet he did not deny the actual Western Pure Land. The reason they meet is that they share the logic of Hwajaeng: the movement from negation to affirmation, the unity of self-power and other-power, and the dissolution of the boundary between the ordinary person and the sage.

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

8. Wonhyo's Theory of Hwajaeng and the Principles of a Symbiotic Economy

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

8. Wonhyo's Theory of Hwajaeng and the Principles of a Symbiotic Economy

This chapter explores how the structure of the Buddhist Four-Gate (Sammun) Hwajaeng examined in Chapter 5 can be applied to the economic problems of today.

8.1. The Historical Development of Hwajaeng Theory

Wonhyo's thought of Hwajaeng was systematized in the Simmun hwajaeng-non (Treatise on the Reconciliation of Disputes in Ten Aspects, 十門和諍論). It is a principle that acknowledges the partial truth held by each position while integrating them within a more comprehensive truth.

Two-term Hwajaeng corresponds to the stereoscopic thinking (Mimesis) of Part 1. Three-term Hwajaeng corresponds to the cyclical thinking (Mythos) of Part 1. Four-term Hwajaeng structurally corresponds to the four modes of correlative thinking in Part 1—Ipche (stereoscopic), Sunhwan (cyclical), Gonggam (empathy), and Yunghap (convergence).

8.2. The Hwajaeng Structure of Economic Theory

The economic problems humanity faces today are likewise ultimately structured as a four-term relation of four economic theories. Each of these schools of thought offers a different answer to the question "What is justice?", yet seen through the lens of Hwajaeng they are mutually complementary as segments (harmony, 和) of the whole cycle.

The following table shows the relationship between traditional economic theories and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng.

Table 9: The Relationship between Traditional Economic Theories and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng

School of Thought	Core Principle	Four Gates	Season	Philosophical Core
Utilitarianism	The greatest happiness of the greatest number (efficiency)	Arising-and-Ceasing Gate (Saengmyeol-mun)	Spring	The autonomous arising (起) of the seed—the eruption of individual vitality
Communitarianism	Shared values and social bonds	Three-Natures Gate (Samseong-mun)	Summer	The efficient expansion of the receptacle-world (器)—maximizing phenomenal abundance
Social Contractarianism	Rational procedure and fair agreement	Suchness Gate (Jinyeo-mun)	Autumn	Cessation into fair rules—universal order and principle
Libertarianism	The individual's absolute right of ownership and freedom	Pure Land Gate (Jeongto-mun)	Winter	The faith-arising (信) of the great vessel called "we"—fundamental solidarity and the One Mind

These four economic theories correspond precisely to the four-seasons cyclical principle of Hwajaeng. Freedom (spring): the economy begins only when individual creativity springs forth. Efficiency (summer): resources must be allocated

efficiently so that society as a whole grows abundant. Fairness (autumn): transparent rules are needed to resolve conflicts over distribution. Solidarity (winter): at the end of the whole process there must be the communal repose of "we are one."

Furthermore, the correspondences with Eastern thought stand out. If the "principle (li, 理)" of Neo-Confucianism is the fairness of social contractarianism, then the "compassion" of Buddhism is the warmth of communitarianism, and the "wu-wei (non-action)" of Daoism is the noninterfering vitality of libertarianism.

8.3. Economic Hwajaeng Seen through Vessel (器) and Arising (起)

The conflicts of the modern economy fundamentally stem from the difference between valuing the "vessel (器, institutions and structures)" and valuing "arising (起, creative energy)." Only when the mutual complementarity of these two concepts is understood from the perspective of Hwajaeng can the opposition among economic theories be resolved.

[Utilitarianism (Arising/起 of spring)] "It is good to enlarge the size of the pie held in the vessel as a whole." It emphasizes outcome-centered efficiency.

[Communitarianism (Vessel/器 of summer)] "We are not isolated vessels. Only within the great vessel (器) of community does the individual's life meaningfully arise (起)." It emphasizes the human being as a correlative existence.

[Social Contractarianism (Cessation/rules of autumn)] "A transparent contract (cessation) that everyone can accept, no matter who becomes the owner of the vessel, must come first." It seeks the legitimacy of procedure.

[Libertarianism (Faith-arising/信 of winter)] "Let not the vessel (the receptacle-world) arbitrarily infringe upon the achievements (起) I have won." It gives top priority to the individual's creative energy.

8.4. The Expansion of Hwajaeng and the Symbiotic Economy

The AI era makes the need for Hwajaeng more urgent than any age in history. The modern economy, immersed solely in the infinite expansion of "spring (utilitarianism)," has lost its "winter (the repose of libertarian freedom)." AI maximizes the speed of this summer and thereby alienates human beings.

The direction of a Hwajaeng-based resolution is as follows. First, acknowledge community (summer) while making it known that community arose from individual freedom (winter). Second, pursue efficiency (summer) while keeping it within the framework of a fair contract (autumn). Third, through Hwajaeng grounded in symmetry (對稱性), pursue a structure that acknowledges the validity of each theory while integrating them cyclically. Fourth, the hyperconnective technology of the AI era becomes the material foundation of Hwajaeng-based connection.

Only when we understand that the economy is not a set of static numbers but a "time of water" that circulates like the four seasons does sustainable peace arrive. When the four great engines of freedom, efficiency, fairness, and solidarity are integrated into a single One-Mind (一心) economic model, the economy of the AI era is transformed into a symbiotic economy (相生經濟).

8.5. The Hwajaeng of World Religions

The Great Master Wonhyo's Hwajaeng (和諍) is a universal meta-model applicable not only to conflicts within Buddhism but also to oppositions among the world's religions. In particular, the three Abrahamic religions—Judaism, Christianity, and Islam—set out from a single root yet have clashed fiercely throughout history. Seen through the lens of Hwajaeng, they share the same essence (nature, 性) while colliding in phenomena (appearance, 相).

From a Hwajaeng perspective, these three religions are not mistaken about one another; rather, they are correlative manifestations in which a single divinity (the One Mind) has revealed itself according to different epochal demands within the "time of water" that is history. What the three religions share is the divinity (性) held within the "receptacle-world (器)"—the vessel that is scripture—and conflict arises when they cling to the shape (相) of that vessel.

The following table shows the relationship between the three Abrahamic religions and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng.

Table 10: The Three Abrahamic Religions and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng

Religion	Season of Hwajaeng	Core Emphasis	Role in Hwajaeng
Judaism	Spring (the beginning of the Law)	The strictness of covenant and law (the rules of the receptacle-world)	The starting point of communal order
Christianity	Summer (the expansion of love)	Faith and universal love (the diffusion of the Dharma-vessel)	Maximizing the energy of love
Islam	Autumn (absolute submission)	Complete devotion to the one God (return through cessation)	Urging the return to essence

Inter-religious conflict in the AI era must likewise be approached through the principle of Hwajaeng. The message of Hwajaeng is to move beyond the exclusivism that "only my own path (起) is right" and to acknowledge that all paths are

ultimately streams of water flowing into a single great ocean (大洋).

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

9. The Practice and Prospects of the Symbiotic Connective Economy

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

9. The Practice and Prospects of the Symbiotic Connective Economy

Money is both a treasury of human freedom and a yoke upon that freedom—a knotty existence that cannot be untangled by anything other than circulation. Modernity, which set out beginning with the attainment of freedom, has today seen the meaning of freedom fade and economic motivation disappear, leading to the loss of economic ethics, the collapse of economic ideology, and even a grave environmental crisis.

The symbiotic connective economy of the AI era, grounded in the four-gate cyclical principle of Wonhyo's Hwajaeng theory, proposes the following four practical tasks.

First, the Hwajaeng of freedom (Suchness Gate) and community (Pure Land Gate). When AI and humans form a relationship that is at once oppositional and mutually complementary (相補), human economic motivation is revived anew. Second, the Hwajaeng of labor (Arising-and-Ceasing Gate) and distribution (Three-Natures Gate). The economic ethics of the AI era require that the benefits of technological progress be fairly distributed across society as a whole. Third, the Hwajaeng of ideological conflict. An economics of Hwajaeng is needed that acknowledges the valid core of each ideology and integrates them cyclically. Fourth, overcoming the environmental crisis.

Korea possesses, from Wonhyo's thought of Hwajaeng, a tradition of integrating all things cyclically. The culture of bibimbap, the Korean Wave (Hallyu), and the cyclical theory of the tri-fold union of Confucianism, Buddhism, and Daoism can play an important role in the flourishing of world culture and the realization of a symbiotic connective economy.

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

10. Conclusion to Part 2: The Future of a Symbiotic Economy through Hwajaeng

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

10. Conclusion to Part 2: The Future of a Symbiotic Economy through Hwajaeng

This study has proposed a new paradigm that combines correlative thinking and Hwajaeng as a survival strategy for humanity in the AI era. Part 1 confirmed the distinctive strengths of human beings in the AI era through the four modes of correlative thinking: Ipche (stereoscopic, 立體), Sunhwan (cyclical, 循環), Gonggam (empathy, 共感), and Yunghap (convergence, 融合). Part 2 clarified how these four modes of correlative thinking correspond precisely to the four-gate structure of Wonhyo's Hwajaeng theory—the Arising-and-Ceasing Gate (spring), the Three-Natures Gate (summer), the Suchness Gate (autumn), and the Pure Land Gate (winter)—and applied this to the Hwajaeng-based integration of the four economic theories.

Hwajaeng conveys the following message to humanity in the AI era: differing viewpoints each possess their own validity, and Hwajaeng is not a way in which one annihilates the others, but rather a mutual subsumption and integration at a higher dimension.

The Symbiotic Connective Economy (相生連結經濟) is the embodiment of the principle of Hwajaeng in the economic domain. When libertarian freedom, utilitarian efficiency, social-contractarian justice, and communitarian solidarity are integrated cyclically like spring, summer, autumn, and winter, the economy of the AI era can be transformed into a symbiotic economy in which all of humanity survives together.

Just as the liberation and cessation of Buddhism possess a dynamic stillness in which body and mind are perfectly unified, the logic of Hwajaeng is humanity's distinctive wisdom that leads the conflicts and oppositions of the AI era toward integration at a higher dimension.